

Ven Anīgha Reddit Archive 2026

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2026

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How to Interpret the Vinaya

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Formal_Breath_2026 2026-06-15 04:44:52

This question is mostly directed towards u/Sister_Medhini and u/Bhikkhu_Anigha since they are the ones most qualified to answer it. I am unsure how exactly to work with the conflict between what I see as three overlapping categories: the Vinaya, the traditional interpretation of the Vinaya, and the practice itself. I'll give a few examples. Pācittiya 35 states that once a bhikkhu has turned down an offer of more food, he cannot then go and eat more food. The background story to this rule makes it clear that it is mostly about having concluded a meal with one donor, and then going and taking food from another donor anyway. However, the Commentary (which my tradition follows) interprets this as meaning that, having refused any offer of food during a meal, one cannot accept any more food and must finish their portion without even leaving their seat. Obviously this interpretation is silly; I should be able to turn down one kind of food and accept another kind during a meal, or be able to get up. It even leads monks to frustration in trying to somehow signal to people that they don't want the food they're being offered without formally refusing it so they can continue to take food. Nevertheless, at least this example is fairly simple to work around — if I followed the Commentary here, it would be just so I don't get told off by my tradition, but I would know that if I didn't follow the Commentary, I wouldn't be doing anything wrong per se. It does show that you have to double check everything you hear people say about the Vinaya, though.

My problem is that, despite the fact that the Commentarial interpretations of the Vinaya are often overtly ridiculous, that doesn't change the fact that even an 'EBT interpretation' of the Vinaya still has to be an interpretation. For example, Ven. Ṭhānissaro's BMC states:

[...] in the West we are left with a somewhat zigzag line separating what are and are not staple foods for the purposes of the rules: Meal pounded from grain is a staple; flour ground from grain is not. Bread made with oat meal, corn meal, wheat germ, etc., would thus be a staple; bread made without any grain meal or eggs would not. The same holds true for pastries, noodles, and pasta.

I feel like someone who is faithful to the spirit of the Vinaya could reasonably either try to preserve the original definition of a staple food here, or rather re-define it such that it includes anything that would be a staple food in the West. But by what criteria should one

make such a decision? My problem is that many of the rules in the Vinaya are not relevant to the actual practice of training the mind, and therefore that an attempt to adequately interpret every rule in the Vinaya becomes more of a scholarly endeavour than a practical one. As we know, the Buddha himself said the minor rules could be abolished. We also don't know for certain that the Vibhaṅga is accurate in preserving the original purpose of a rule. Additionally, the interpretation of the specifics of the Vinaya differs within Theravāda Buddhism so much that one cannot even claim that interpreting these rules is important for social harmony either. By following that criteria, one would instead often have to go along with the Commentarial interpretation followed by one's monastery (as indeed I do, in order to avoid any criticism). If EBT monastics were to start ignoring the traditional rule of having food placed directly in their hands, it would most likely cause more disruption than it's worth, for example.

So if many of these rules are basically historical fossils, and they are not directly relevant to the practice (as is hinted at in the Suttas and the Vinaya itself many times), how should Westerners who are concerned about authenticity interpret them? For example, it is not uncommon for me to be offered small things like garlic, berries, chocolate, etc. in the evening. My guess would be that by a strictly academic reading of the Vinaya, these would not be allowable. But why would I go through the social awkwardness of turning these offers down and risking a discussion about the Vinaya if I know it isn't even unwholesome for me to accept it? Trying to draw strict lines here creates many silly results, such as debating at what point milk turns into buttermilk, or not being allowed by your monastery to drink milk in the afternoon but still being allowed to eat some solid foods. I feel like even a faithful EBT reading of the Vinaya could fall into the same trap of ridiculous legalism that the Commentaries fell into many times. It feels to me like dealing with these boundaries is more unrelated to the actual intentions present in one's mind than practicing with the boundaries of the 8 precepts as a householder. Obviously I would take the 10 precepts as fundamental to the life of a monastic (if *vikāla bhojana* is defined as not eating a proper meal after noon, in order to avoid all the nitpicking I mentioned before), but I am unsure how to deal with the minor rules. Thank you!

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-06-16 18:28:30

My problem is that many of the rules in the Vinaya are not relevant to the actual practice of training the mind

True, but the fact is that you will often be more inconvenienced by dismissing them than by simply keeping them, as even in the West you will still often be perceived in a bad light by those with EBT knowledge if you dismiss even minor rules. And those rules certainly don't *interfere* with the training of the mind either.

So you end up in basically the same situation as the elders in the same council: the Buddha did say the minor rules could be dismissed, but trying to implement that allowance will just create unnecessary criticism from laity and arguments within the Sangha.

That also means that it's not terribly relevant for you as an individual whether a certain

rule or custom is “EBT-based,” or developed through commentaries or Asian culture. Back then they had to do things to cater to people’s arbitrary expectations. Nowadays it’s the same, just that the ones holding the expectations happen to be Buddhist.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-06-17 18:34:02 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

But does that mean that when I am offered small pieces of food in the evening like chocolate or garlic, or the five tonics even when I’m not sick — things that I know would probably not be acceptable under the original framework of the Vinaya but are for some reason considered so by my tradition now — it is okay to accept them for the sake of non-conflict?

If greed is the motivation (i.e., the arisen state of your mind at the time, not a theoretical inference) then you shouldn’t accept the tonics even if they are fully allowable. As long as you never compromise on that, everything else is secondary. And you will be distracted from that criterion if you put the technicalities first and think that you are “more pure” simply by following “the original framework” (which is an easy trap to fall into).

Venerable Anigha and Venerable Medhini please have pity on me

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** None 2026-05-26 17:56:59

[deleted]

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-28 17:36:46

In my doubt, last night, I decided to see what it would feel like to have that pressure endure. So I thought up some lustful images, and started masturbating to the point where I was close to ejaculation, and I had to absorb myself in the fantasies to keep going. I stopped and observed what would happen in my mind. There was an urge to keep going, and as soon as I stopped willfully ignoring it, it stopped pressuring me. I went to bed without trouble.

Enduring the pressure on the right level means not thinking up the lustful images to begin with, let alone masturbating. Whatever change of course happens after those choices is really just containing the defeat, not victory.

So it sounds like you just have to take the precepts and celibacy more seriously. From where you are standing, that will undoubtedly lead to covering up/suppressing things less, and there is no point in worrying about subtler cover ups until that’s sorted.

Is treating gender dysphoria through medical intervention acting out of craving?

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Emergency_Win_3698 2026-05-26 15:33:38

Side note: I'm making another post specifically for this question because the last one was supposed to be about monastic options for a person that stays on HRT and gets some surgeries to address their body dysphoria, and it sort of went off track. I have also discussed this question with others (including privately) and I don't feel that a consensus was ever reached. I would appreciate any insight into this issue.

Description of my situation: I experience intense dread when I imagine indefinitely ceasing the medications I currently take that suppress my androgen levels (and raise estradiol) in order to prevent further masculinization from occurring. I also experience dread when I imagine indefinitely foregoing surgeries and trying to accept my body as it is.

On top of that dread, there is a baseline of wrongness/unpleasantness, escalating sometimes to a considerable level of distress (though it is not a constant) that is amplified when I focus on a given feature that is male/masculine. But it is always palpable as a baseline unpleasant quality of experience that is present the second I wake up. This is worse for secondary sex characteristics like bone and cartilage development, increased upper body musculature, balding, facial and body hair (rather than genitalia for which my aversion tends to be comparatively weaker). Social situations tend to amplify this issue by increasing hypervigilant attention to a cluster of traits (e.g., shoulder width, height, face, skull, hands, feet, etc.), usually resulting in more intense distress than when I am alone, though it depends on the circumstances.

Detransitioning *feels* like it would be self-mortification because of the distress that I expect it would result in. But I also acknowledge that the fact I feel so much dread and aversion toward this issue is potentially evidence that I am incredibly attached—perhaps more so than to anything else. Why, for example, do I even take the HRT? I do so because I feel a lot of anxiety and dread around masculinizing any more. So, there is clearly aversion toward that present.

Also, no matter how I justify it to myself, medically transitioning feels like a diversion/distraction from the path and from nibbana, as I am essentially trying to make the body be the way I want it to be and hold the belief that I cannot achieve peace (or even successfully practice) otherwise. I realize that I had the belief that I “just need to fix this” and *then* I can take the practice off the backburner and dedicate my life to fully uprooting suffering. But that's not really logical, is it?

At present I am working a job in order to cover the surgeries I would need to make a dent in my dysphoria. So, the stakes are genuinely high and deciding to call the whole thing off would be a huge decision for which I would need substantial justification.

Questions I have (apart from post title):

1. Do you think that going through with surgeries and such to modify the body will per-

- manently increase attachment to it in the long run and/or obstruct the right view?
2. If medical transition is a poor idea because of the above, what should I do instead (keeping in mind that this isn't an identity issue of "I feel like [preferred gender]." It manifests as often intense distress that has in the past compelled me to desire death)?

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-26 20:06:15

There is no doubt that these interventions constitute acting out of craving (and the intense dread you experience at the prospect of stopping them only proves it further). Pursuing them is reinforcing the deep-seated assumption that the escape from suffering lies in changing the circumstances.

The thing is that, going by what you describe, it's likely not realistic to stop it all at once. It may be too much pressure for you to withstand at this point, and you may well end up in a worse position in the aftermath of quitting too rapidly.

The more realistic course of action is to gradually cut back on the interventions, while also starting to challenge all the emotional attitudes driving you to them rather than taking them for granted and justifying them.

The fact that there could be a minimum degree of treatment necessary to prevent yourself from falling apart—at this time, due to insufficient training of the mind—doesn't mean that you have to accept other measures that build on top of that. And it is almost certain that you are currently doing more than that bare minimum.

By going closer to that minimum, the aversion will come up in a more manageable degree, and that will create some basis for training and going against the grain. Up until you can finally abandon the whole thing when the aversion in regard to *that* isn't strong enough to completely overwhelm you as it might now.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-27 14:51:37 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

Why is that diagnostic? Are you saying that the severity of the condition is what justifies withdrawing the treatment?

The severity of suffering shows the extent of craving (that's how it works across the board).

Couldn't this charge be leveled at any form of medicine that is treating a condition that causes suffering?

Not in the same way. The crucial difference is that most conditions can exist independently of craving and suffering, whereas gender dysphoria cannot. That means that treating it externally can never be a neutral choice from a Dhamma perspective.

Is there any way that I could continue to intervene without acting out of it/fueling the craving, like how one could take pain medication with a mind

of craving without the intention being itself rooted in craving?

Therefore, no.

But just to repeat, this doesn't mean that you must stop the interventions overnight if that has a high risk of overwhelming you. The point is to start valuing and moving in the opposite direction, not to immediately arrive at its end.

I'm not sure how exactly to go about doing this.

Reflecting on the condition as objectively as you can until you see with more certainty that it is directly tied to unwholesome states of mind, and is not something you can simply accept and try to develop wholesome states on top of. Essentially, getting to the point where intellectually at least, you see that abandoning the treatments is what is in your ultimate welfare.

Then, weaning off the treatments will still be unpleasant and doubts about the decision might still arise from time to time, but you will have grounds for sticking to it regardless.

I am looking into getting some surgeries, which would likely put a dent in it (but not get rid of all the aversion either per se, as some things cannot be easily fixed or at all).

That could be a way of going beyond the bare minimum. It's definitely going beyond what you currently have, which will only make reversing direction more difficult.

But I would say that it's not very manageable right now because I am in constant pain and discomfort over it and it causes significant dysfunction.

What I mean with "manageable" can still be quite unpleasant. If you can sustain it without having a mental breakdown then it's manageable.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-28 04:52:15 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

What makes gender dysphoria special in this regard?

The fact that the condition itself (rather than a consequence of it) is called "dysphoria"—meaning unease/dissatisfaction/unhappiness—highlights what makes it different.

but could not there be a baseline of pre-cognitive disagreeableness (like the disturbance of the six sense bases) or a kind of perceptual mismatch that would persist even in an arahant with it?

No, because such disagreeableness would require the mind still having concern for the body.

So, it seems like the only reason it is manageable at present is the fact that I am working toward surgeries, and ceasing those efforts would therefore increase the likelihood of having a mental breakdown and of the suicidal thoughts re-turning full force.

That's possible. But you have to realize that no amount of displeasure produces those reactions by itself. In other words, you have to take full responsibility for them.

See how that goes before deciding to go for the surgeries.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-28 17:43:49 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

You cease to see yourself as a victim in despair and renounce the bittersweet gratification that comes from that attitude (which is the direction every mind tends to go whenever something is highly unpleasant). You maintain the context that despairing is a choice, and that it only worsens the displeasure.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-29 04:09:45 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

Are you saying that arahants don't feel any sense of disagreeability?

No. A dislike for the given body's male/female features and a desire for the opposite is not just a neutral and unavoidable disagreeability on the level of hunger or physical illness. It's a symptom of mental affinity towards the body, similar to what this Sutta describes.

Question on the nature of HH's critique of other traditions

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** account-7 2026-05-21 16:26:43

Hello! Just a brief question to understand what the Hillside Hermitage stance is on this. I have heard - most of which I agree with - many thoughtful and useful critiques on almost every other tradition's pedagogy and presentation of the Dhamma. However, I want to better understand the scope of this critique as I, potentially intentionally, haven't heard a direct answer in all I've seen the past couple years here. Though I think it would be useful to hear if offered.

I will not name names as to put anyone answering in the awkward (and probably useless/impossible) position of naming specific individuals who do or do not teach the Dhamma, but is the HH position that alternative frameworks are structurally incapable of producing liberation because they operate on a fundamental misconception? Such as prominent Thai Forest teachers, Chan/Zen, or veering a bit into perennialism but even non-Buddhist contemplative traditions like Advaita? And in this case, would their "attainments" just be chalked up to maintaining refined states of samadhi?

Or is it more just a generalized concern for the preservation of the dhamma in its most efficient, canonically accurate form. Dismissing not the potential validity of those paths to lead to fruitions, but their efficacy and the massive traps/potential pitfalls that is seen as mitigated within HH instructions; while leaving room for the possibility that individuals could make their way into right view despite a flawed framework?

Thank you for your time!

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-22 04:34:40

HH position that alternative frameworks are structurally incapable of producing liberation because they operate on a fundamental misconception?

Yes, it's a structural issue whereby those frameworks cannot lead to *anything but* pitfalls. Becoming accomplished in them puts one in a worse position than one started in (see below).

A less ideal or efficient framework leading the same goal would not warrant dismissal.

And in this case, would their "attainments" just be chalked up to maintaining refined states of samadhi?

Wrong samādhi, wrong knowledge, and wrong liberation. In simple terms that means: not experiencing (perceptible) dukkha because the circumstances that trigger it have been altered, not because craving in regard to all possible circumstances has diminished. And that is what delusion, the most insidious of the three defilements, boils down to.

Of course, this need not be the stated mechanism of operation of a certain practice in order to be the actual mechanism. That mechanism can be embedded in an endless array of different narratives and descriptions.

Request: sequential series for beginners?

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** tejveer 2026-05-15 02:33:15

I have been in conversation with an old friend for some time about the dhamma - at least my understanding of it.

I had spent some time uncovering some views he had tacitly due to the scientific culture we were brought up in. Since they were challenged, he seems more open to consider the possibility of future birth, the weight of which he seems to be realizing to some degree now.

Because of this he showed some interest in HH's teachings, except I had nowhere I could point for starters. The slovenian videos? The sri lankan videos?

Unfortunately, HH's teachings now, even though they seem more targetted towards beginners, feel even more difficult to enter than they were before. It feels almost as if someone needs the context accumulated across all 500 videos and years of trying to make sense of the suttas and their pali to really begin making any sense of the new videos.

I think this is because of the following reasons:

1. The format of the videos. They are conversations between the venerables themselves, in which there is a questioner and answerer. The questioner assumes the

- place of an abstract viewer, rather than actual live viewers.
2. The content of the videos. The content is often a part of the whole of HH's teachings, where how that part fits into the whole is only sometimes mentioned, or when it is, it is overridden by the multiplicity of topics covered.
 3. The lack of hierarchy in the videos. The videos seem like a bunch of topics concatenated together: A B C D E F ..., which is natural since IRL conversations flow without hierarchy; as new questions come up, the topics change. But this is extremely costly on the viewers because, in my estimate, every video has at least 15-20 topics changes. Viewers have to hold context of the discussion, see how it might be related to the multiple changes that previously occurred, process incoming discussions, remember very important bits. The same video may go from talking about sati, to yoniso manasikara, to a sutta, to sense restraint, to avijja, to another sutta, to meditation techniques, etc. This means the very important parts of the video, say topic B, F, H, are lost since the video is so linear.

This may be compared in contrast to a pre-planned video on a subject that has an explicit hierarchy.

Say there is a doctor who is giving an update on the medication plan to their patient over a 20 minute video. They plan that the starting 5 minutes are for introducing the purpose of this new plan; how it fits into the overall plan of recovery. The next 5 are for addressing existing medication. The next 10 are for new medication.

In the new medication, they will have 5 minutes for what the new medication is, why it's needed, and its sides effects. The next 5 for how to use it.

There is a clear hierarchy here. Three top-level topics: context, current medication, new medication. And the 3rd has two sub-topics: Introduction, application.

Compare this to if the doctor made a 1 hour video in conversation with another doctor. They begin by introducing the new medication, then the research paper that supports this, then the research papers that don't support this medication and the issues with them, then the context of the new medication, then some new research papers, then the application of the new medication, then the side effects, then its purpose, etc.

Of course, it is completely up to the venerables on whether this is of any benefit. But I think it would be very beneficial to existing members and to others outside the community willing to learn to have a course-like presentation of the core of the dhamma by HH, that builds from ground up.

The whole of HH's teachings can be divided into positive and negative parts. The positive is concerned with their own views, the negative with addressing views that will obstruct others from understanding/considering HH's positive views.

The positive part is concerned centrally with the HH's aim: to teach for the uprooting not management of suffering. Then this would be split off into two branches that elaborate on this distinction: on management and on uprooting.

In order for newcomers to understand why management is problematic, they must un-

derstand how HH understands the actual uprooting of suffering. So it is possible to start off from the uprooting branch and address that as its own topic in a video.

This branch would address what the root of the problem is (craving), what the solution is (removing craving), and how that solution is implemented (i.e., it would introduce the notions of the four noble truths and the five aggregates).

Then it's possible to more easily make sense of what management is (namely, everything that is not addressing the root), and why it's problematic (it doesn't address the root).

Then one could exit the positive branch and address the negative branch. Chiefly, meditation techniques.

The course/series could be divided in 3/4th part to the positive part, and 1/4th to the negative. In the positive, 1/2 is spent on uprooting, 1/2 on management. And the same hierarchical division goes down more and more, and every video would itself be just another hierarchical division.

This would just be one among many ways of presenting HH's central views. But I personally think this would help save much time on both HH's part as well as on the viewers' part due to the clarity it can bring.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-15 14:30:31

I'm sure we will continue to refine our approach to teaching, but the lack of a "course-like structure"—and the lack of hand-holding of the listener in general—is deliberate and will continue to be that way. It's the least we can do for an distant audience to keep them on the side of seeing (or at least trying to see) for themselves the experiential truths that our material is grounded in, rather than being distracted by intellectual connections with ideas they've heard before (including from us).

Giving in to the hunger for neatly presented information that newcomers will naturally have is a misstep rooted in yourself not understanding what the Dhamma is and how it is realized. What that actually achieves is helping people fall into the trap of thinking that they understand what they don't. They start to feel that the teachings "make sense" to them while their life and mental habits continue in the same trajectory as before, and that's a worse position than not having heard the teachings at all.

Merely making our teachings publicly available inevitably allows a number of people to fall into this trap, and we wouldn't want to increase that number.

“Doing Nothing” Meditation

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** nubuda 2026-05-13 15:55:09

If you sit or lie down with eyes closed and just rest for long enough, eventually the thoughts begin to slow down and the mind settles on effortless awareness of the body

breathing. The clarity of the mind increases significantly if you practice it regularly. I think this is how Buddha experienced jhana when he was still a kid chilling under a tree.

Does Hillside Hermitage support such meditation? In my experience it

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-14 04:21:42

Does Hillside Hermitage support such meditation?

No. Such practices play no role whatsoever on the path, and we have extensively explained why (as well as what samādhi actually is) in our teachings.

the right peace before stream entry

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** bodily_heartfulness 2026-05-05 22:55:56

I sometimes reflect upon the downsides of relationships, the dangers of sexuality, and so on. Sometimes, as a result of these reflections, there will be a sense of *unencumberedness*, a sense of the mind being more free and open, not weighed down by the stickiness, the weight, the insecurities, the desires, of it all.

I have a few questions regarding this.

1. Is this type of peace dangerous? Is it to be cultivated?
2. Is this “cheating”? In that, if this is practiced alongside of restraint, then restraint becomes easier because the mind, on occasions, will have a decreased level of thirst towards sensuality. Does this impact the training, because part of the goal of the precepts and virtue is to train the mind *in regards to* the pressure, not to not have pressure at all.
3. Continuing that train of thought, in general, if certain contemplations reduce the pressure, is that bad?

(Note that this is all pre-stream-entry, when one doesn't have the right reference.)

My own answer to some of these questions would be:

The purpose of these types of contemplations is to develop the right context, so that one does not act out in body, speech, or mind when one is pressured by sensuality. If these reflections lead to a temporary reduction in the pressure, or some temporary sense of freedom, that is fine, but that is not the point. Trying to decrease the pressure, or even trying to increase the pressure, is besides the point - the goal is not management, but the fundamental change in view, which means putting things in the right order, so that sensuality is first seen as dangerous and *never* worth engaging in.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-07 05:18:35

Continuing that train of thought, in general, if certain contemplations reduce the pressure, is that bad?

What is bad is to develop an association that restraint ought to be supported by peace, rather than being non-negotiable regardless of how painful it becomes.

That association will obstruct right view even if the peace you're describing is along the right lines because it means you continue to ignore the true nature of craving (which applies regardless of how you currently feel).

I have created a free Sutta companion app - To implement Gradual training need review from hh

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** True-Grape2605 2026-05-05 13:11:26

Bhante and friends,

I have built a free, offline sutta reading app called Sutta Companion — primarily for laypeople who want to study the Pāli Nikāyas and implement a daily practice based on the gradual training.

The app uses Bhikkhu Sujato's translations from the SuttaCentral database. It is free, ad-free, and fully offline. It is currently live on Android.

I am writing here specifically because I have recently added a practice module built around the gradual training as described in DN 2, MN 27, and MN 53 — from dāna and sīla through indriya saṃvara, sati-sampajañña, the five hindrances, paññā, brahmavihārā, samādhi, and vipassanā. Each stage in the app references the canonical source and uses short passages from Bhikkhu Sujato's translations to describe what is being tracked and why it appears at that point in the sequence.

I am a layperson and a software developer. I am not a monastic, not a scholar, and not trained in Pāli beyond basic reading. I have done my best to represent the gradual training faithfully but I am certain there are gaps, misrepresentations, or errors I am not qualified to catch myself.

Specifically I would welcome review on:

- Whether the sequence I have used (dāna → sīla → akushala kamma-patha → indriya saṃvara → sati-sampajañña → pañca nīvaraṇa → paññā → brahmavihārā → samādhi → vipassanā) accurately reflects the canonical gradual training or introduces distortions, although it is not hardcore sequence we need to follow there since lot of things can work parallel and helping each other parts .
- Whether the descriptions of each stage, which I have tried to draw from the suttas directly rather than from secondary sources, are faithful to the texts

— Whether the framing of samādhi as something that arises naturally from the preceding stages rather than as a technique to be practised is correctly represented — I relied primarily on the stock gradual training formula in DN 2 and the rose-apple tree recollection in MN 36

— Whether anything in the practice module, particularly around the hindrances and vipassanā sections, risks misleading a practitioner or giving the wrong impression of what the practice involves

I have tried to be honest with users about the limits of what an app can track. I have also included a note in the path module saying I am a layperson, that there may be errors, and inviting corrections.

If any of you have the time and inclination to look at this and tell me what is wrong, I would be genuinely grateful. The app is available on the Play Store — I can also share screenshots of the practice module and path descriptions specifically if that is easier.

I built this for my own practice and for laypeople like me who want something grounded in the early texts rather than in modern mindfulness repackaging. If the Dhamma parts are not right, the app does not serve that purpose regardless of how well the software works.

With respect, Kapil

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-07 05:47:04

The app looks great software-wise, although there some issues with the “Practice settings” section:

- (1) In the first step of the Gradual Training, the third precept is celibacy, not just abstaining from sensual misconduct.
- (2) Pinpointing the specific sense base in the sense restraint section is unnecessary and will likely lead to overthinking.
- (3) In the Samādhi section, it shows the suggestion “30 min ānāpanasati, aiming for first jhāna,” clearly reflecting the common wrong view that jhāna is an absorbed state that “comes to you” after a certain period of some attentional exercise.

More generally, the act of logging per se—for anything beyond the precepts, which *are* clear-cut— is a strong indicator that a person is approaching the practice as just another technique/mechanical performance, and that means they are certainly not doing any of the right work on the mental level.

Right Restraint or Wrong Restraint?

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** EggplantNumerous8026 2026-04-30 21:10:34

I have trouble keeping restraint and not breaking the precepts.

For example i get a lustful/sexual thought, in the moment i comprehend that this thought is dangerous and against the goal/virtue (Dhamma practice), not the thought itself but its implications, its leading me a certain way (pressure), and in the moment even though i know logically that this way is leading to danger and suffering and not ultimate satisfaction. I still get hooked by the prospect of pleasure and relief, which builds up more internal conflict and resistance to the idea of acting out until i completely lose perspective and become an animal/beast and act out.

and when i try to understand where i went wrong after breaking the virtue (HH and SH youtube channels) its many different answers that are correct but i feel they don't solve the problem. Such as you dont understand the danger enough, or you didn't endure on the right level, or you are not developed in the body, you chose to give in.

ive watched pretty much all the videos of HH and SH and many multiple times even up to 10 times some of them, and i've contemplated the teachings, all this over a time span of multiple years, and it all makes sense to me logically, i believe/have faith it is right. ive been long past the dunning-kruger effect, i know also logically that i dont understand truly what they are talking about because im not a sotapanna.

i feel like ive had more than enough information about how to practice the Dhamma, its just that im not restraint enough. and they say you have to purify bodily and verbal conduct before you can purify or even see the mind and start to purify that (simile of purifying gold). and i get that to a degree, but in my experience its the mind/mental states and the thought that pressure me to seek relief (yes from that greater underlying pain of suffering), so if these things originate at the mind and it presents me with the mental thoughts it want me to act out from (like Ajahn said the mind has a mind of its own) why do i have to stop my bodily behavior, which is way down the line of giving in and acting out of craving, like the mind gets a sensual desire first but i am told that as a puthujhana i cant see my mind thus focus on "impeccable virtue". isnt it just better to stop the craving in its emerging domain first, before it spills out into other domains because yes in a fundamental level you cant handle the pressure or endure on the right level when you have lost your perspective (because i got careless). and somehow i have to balance this with training gradually also, so not doing to much at once? but not too little as well? How to determine what pressure to prioritize to not act out from, when all pressure shouldn't be acted out from? Just how do i get to the actual goal and understand the dhamma? any ideas? In one video on SH bhante Anigha said that "when you want to act out, just dont" (very close to this atleast), and like this is stating the obvious. and its correct but its not that helpfull, is he implaying that we have ultimate control/choice? so a fully addicted drug addict for >10 years or other type of addict can just stop when he decides? its like yeah its his choice that frees him but that doesnt mean he wont relapse, like at the same time tha wild animal gets compared to a strong animal like a wild bull elephant while we are the weaker animal that has to tame it smart. like we cannot just overpower it by sheer will, or can we? is the ability to consciously choose just a muscle that has to be trained as much a possible, so that when unwholesome desire arises we can stay clear from acting out? if so how to prevent burning out and relapse?

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-05-03 04:04:45

why do i have to stop my bodily behavior, which is way down the line of giving in and acting out of craving,

Because intentional bodily actions are the coarsest mental actions you can do.

so a fully addicted drug addict for >10 years or other type of addict can just stop when he decides?

Yes, because his body simply can't take the drug on its own; he has to mentally choose that.

Each time he takes the drug again, he is deciding that stopping the pains of withdrawal is more important than eventually being free from the addiction. So, he must abstain from making that decision no matter what (which is very straightforward, just not easy in the beginning).

Storage, items and Monks

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Hard_Tack4 2026-04-26 17:06:42

What degree of personal items is allowable or a good idea for someone who is considering becoming a monk? The HH monks seem to have phones, maybe even laptops, cameras, audio equipment, have presumably used tickets, probably have medicines etc. What is reasonable? I have read that the rules about personal possession of even medicine like frankincense is very restricted, you couldn't have 200 grams on your person it seems without breaking a rule. Ofc many monks even use money which is unambiguously bad. What should I get for myself? Can I get a tent and a nice backpack? An e-ink-tablet? A small camera? Some pens? An Mp3/4?

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-27 04:49:50

I have read that the rules about personal possession of even medicine like frankincense is very restricted, you couldn't have 200 grams on your person it seems without breaking a rule.

There is no such rule in the Vinaya. Every monk is personally responsible for checking his motivations for possessing things.

With certain things, no matter how externally "luxurious", you can harbor no internal desire and not be significantly bothered if they are lost, whereas there can be "modest" and inexpensive things (and living beings as well) that you would passionately protect even though they are not strictly necessary to survive and to practice. That passion, not the things, is the problem, and you will be unable to address that problem if your focus is on the level of what and how much you have.

How do you practice tranquility?

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** nubuda 2026-04-20 09:06:42

If I understand correctly, Ajahn N. does not consider any kind of relaxing meditation part of dhamma practice. I was listening to one of his dhamma talks and he mentioned that instead of calming meditation, people should instead practice sitting quietly and contemplating certain dhamma topics. This is of course great but it has limitations. There is a sutta (MN19) which clearly explains that there is no danger in skillful thinking but too much of even skillful thinking will tire the body and stress the mind. So how do you practice tranquility according to Hillside Hermitage teachings? My definition of relaxing meditation is very flexible. I believe even sweeping floors or picking berries or laying in bed with resting awareness qualifies as relaxing meditation.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-20 13:48:06

So how do you practice tranquility according to Hillside Hermitage teachings?

The first, non-negotiable step is giving up sensuality. Whatever a person who hasn't done this can achieve is not tranquility—the absence of craving—but is merely shifting their substantial mass of craving onto something else (e.g., the sensual bliss obtained in a state of absorption, often mistaken for tranquility).

From then onwards, you progress in the Gradual Training up until you reach the level of purifying your mind from the hindrances, which is done by understanding them as mental activities that are harmful, not by any attentional technique or focusing effort whatsoever.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-21 04:56:26 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

The pleasure that comes from what is generally mistaken as samādhi today. Pleasure that comes from engagement with a sense object rather than from withdrawal.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-21 05:15:37 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

Just like the sutta I referenced says, too much thinking of dhamma topics can cause stress despite it being skillful thoughts.

It doesn't say that you simply decide to engage in a calming practice out of a view that skillful thoughts are tiresome. You develop the skillful thoughts until those have become the mind's natural inclination and unwholesome thoughts have subsided.

If that's actually completed, you won't need a special practice to calm yourself down. You removed the greatest source of disturbance by undoing the unwholesome thoughts, and

now with the wholesome thoughts, recognizing that the subtle burden they entail is no longer necessary will be enough for the mind to become internally calm (meaning it's preoccupied with neither wholesome nor unwholesome thoughts).

Whereas before that point, you only have two options apart from the wholesome thoughts: the blatant unwholesome thoughts, and distractions such as “relaxing meditation.” Both are stressful compared to actual samādhi, where you don't have to do anything at all in order to be calm.

Question regarding interpretation and application of Pātimokkha rules

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Sa_Mahe_ri 2026-04-10 13:02:08

Dear Venerables,

I am a sāmaṇerī in training to become a bhikkhunī. I would very much welcome input not only from the monks who have already undertaken higher ordination or are going to in the future, but also from nuns who have not—since I imagine that you have reflected on these questions as well.

I find myself struggling to understand how to relate properly to my future Pātimokkha rules—especially those that are not/ no longer directly connected to unwholesome behavior, and where the interpretation is not clear-cut.

The most obvious rule that is difficult for a modern bhikkhunī is Saṅghādisesa 3:

If a nun walks to the next inhabited area by herself (Bhante Brahmali) / goes among villages alone (Ajahn Thanissaro), or crosses a river by herself, or spends the night apart by herself, or lags behind her companions by herself, then that nun has committed an immediate offense entailing formal probation and suspension.

Yā pana bhikkhunī ekā vā gāmantaraṃ gaccheyya, ekā vā nadīpāraṃ gaccheyya, ekā vā rattim vippavaseyya, ekā vā gaṇamhā ohiyeyya, ayampi bhikkhunī paṭhamāpattikaṃ dhammaṃ āpannā nissāraṇīyaṃ saṅghādisesaṃ.

This is especially challenging because it is a serious offense. Interpretations of what exactly is prohibited and what is allowed vary greatly, and when I reflect on how I might interpret this rule for myself (as I have considerable freedom in this regard in my monastery), I cannot come to a clear conclusion.

So I am not necessarily looking for a definitive answer on how to interpret this specific rule (but if you have any thoughts on that, please go ahead). Rather, I would appreciate any guidance on how to approach rules that are not entirely clear or that allow for multiple interpretations—how one might arrive at a well-grounded decision in such cases.

At the same time, I would also welcome input from those familiar with Pāli regarding which translation is more accurate. One version seems to suggest that I could still spend the day in seclusion in the forest, as long as I am not intending to travel to another village (which would align with suttas depicting bhikkhunīs being alone in the forest). The other interpretation, however, sounds more like one is not allowed to leave one's village by oneself at all.

And regarding precepts that are not necessarily unwholesome in themselves, but are nowadays commonly interpreted in a different way than the literal wording suggests—does one simply go along with such established interpretations, or is there a more principled way to approach them?

For example:

Confession 85: traveling in a vehicle (for bhikkhunīs, in contrast to bhikkhus, in the Pātimokkha)

If a nun who is not ill travels in a vehicle, she commits an offense entailing confession.

According to Ajahn Thanissaro:

“In modern times, ‘ill’ is interpreted here as meaning too weak to reach one's destination on foot within the available time.”

Any further reflections on how to put the Pātimokkha rules into practice are very welcome.

With respectful regards,
Sāmaṇerī Mahesī

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-12 13:09:13

how to approach rules that are not entirely clear or that allow for multiple interpretations—how one might arrive at a well-grounded decision in such cases.

Reading the origin story to see what exactly the rule is meant to prevent, and how it connects either to the restraint of defilements or to avoiding unnecessary trouble and criticism.

Not having that perspective leads to the absurd attitudes you see with certain rules in a lot of monasteries. A common one is obsessing over a few technicalities to (supposedly) avoid an offense while ignoring how the overall nature of the action clearly violates the spirit of a rule and the training in general.

One version seems to suggest that I could still spend the day in seclusion in the forest, as long as I am not intending to travel to another village

I would read it simply as “going into a village.” The phrasing of the Pāli is by itself somewhat ambiguous, but this reading aligns both with the event in the origin story and the Chinese parallels of that rule.

And regarding precepts that are not necessarily unwholesome in themselves, but are nowadays commonly interpreted in a different way than the literal wording suggests—does one simply go along with such established interpretations

Yes, as long as the established interpretations are reasonable.

Bhikkhuni Pāc. 85 is clearly one of the rules that was entirely based on cultural perceptions of the time. The takeaway is to not travel in ways that would draw the same criticism of “being like laywomen who enjoy sensual pleasures.”

Ironically, in modern times all the vehicles that under that rule are allowed for an ill bhikkhuni would generally draw worse criticism than just “being indulgent.” That shows how you have to exercise your own judgement in interpreting such rules.

Clarification of “no high and luxurious beds” precept?

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** spiffyhandle 2026-04-08 11:50:42

Is the 8th precept only about what I deliberately use for sleeping at night and deliberate naps during the day? Or would it also prohibit using comfortable couches and recliners during the day? Would it prohibit laying awake on a high or luxurious bed but NOT sleeping on it?

I don’t understand the intent of the precept so I can’t gauge its particulars. I’ve looked at references to sleep in the vinaya and suttas and I’m not discerning a universal principle.

I looked in the virtue wiki and all I saw was

“If the seven precepts are your default, then on Uposatha days you would up the ante and keep the full eight precepts. This would add not sleeping on a high and comfortable bed and not eating past noon.”

In the talks to lay people the Buddha says you observe the 8 precepts because you’re emulating an arahant.

As long as they live, the perfected ones give up high and luxurious beds. They sleep in a low place, either a cot or a straw mat. I, too, for this day and night will give up high and luxurious beds. I’ll sleep in a low place, either a cot or a straw mat. I will observe the sabbath by doing as the perfected ones do in this respect.’

The Vinaya, which goes beyond practice and takes into account social norms and maintaining good relationships with lay people, it prohibits having beds that with legs that are too high and also stuffed benches and couches. The connection between a height of a bed and it’s comfort makes no sense to me. If you had a plain bunk bed are you automatically breaking the precept just because it’s tall? What does that have to do with dhamma?

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<https://suttacentral.net/pli-tv-bu-vb-pc88/en/brahmali?lang=en&layout=plain&reference=none¬es=>

‘If a monk has a bed or a bench made upholstered with cotton down, it is to be stripped, and he commits an offense entailing confession.’”

So perhaps there is something about not possessing comfortable furniture, in general that is problematic? I am unsure.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-11 05:27:33

It’s about not using furniture that is very likely to be misused. Namely, for indulging in the pleasure of lying down and giving in to mental laziness rather than resting the body when needed.

Secondarily, it’s about avoiding ostentatiousness, which is another way of losing the context of what a bed/furniture is for.

Building the foundations

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** baubleballs 2026-04-06 19:07:09

hello. Stated simply, this is a question about whether seclusion is counterproductive without a strong foundation in virtue.

Looking back, I’m realizing I’ve neglected virtue during my last several months of lay practice in a secluded environment. I periodically make and lose progress. The daily meal is very brief and the time alone feels overwhelming. After time progressing or creating tension, I will sometimes do things as coarse on the level of the precepts, like: taking allowables only when others aren’t around—in a way a fourth precept breach; tracking calories out of concern for my appearance—beautification breach; and so on.

The stress came to the point a while ago where I increasingly took sensual bait to the point of giving up and breaking several precepts. They were my (series of) choices. I confessed online but didn’t tell others. I have recovered and been transparent since. I was pardoned and, for the first time since I arrived, I feel calm. I’m still stressed, because my daily gratification is limited to the meal, but I am not breaking precepts. Still, I am often tempted. I am not “steady”.

The progress I did make in renunciation, I think, was not pleasurable or stable because it was not based on a steady moral character. I wonder if my difficulties have been owed to not having developed much in lay life. I came here without much experience in keeping the 8 precepts. In fact, I even occasionally broke the 5 at home. As a result, it feels like practice here has been mostly painfully giving up everything with periods of indulgence.

It strikes me that while understanding can be genuine, consistently aligning one’s choices with it is not easy. Danger frequently and personally becomes apparent to me, but my actions revert to worldliness. Are these two different things—understanding and true

training in making good choices? Is the latter more important? Can I not rely on my understanding to do the work for me? Should virtue, by willpower, come first?

I have a sincere sense of urgency and desire to practice but feel disoriented by my own struggles and inauthenticity in weathering the turbulence of this new lifestyle. Right now, for example, the urgency is apparent, but this isn't the first time.

I believed my breaches were overly problematic to stay, so I planned to leave, recover, and dedicate some time at home to truly becoming a virtuous person for the first time in my life. Having tasted the pleasure of renunciation, I wanted to be a lay person for a while, living alone, working a job, and practicing aloofness in regards to worldly pleasures, before going to another, "easier" secluded environment after a while.

However, when I opened up, some monks urged me to stay. I now feel at ease rather than remorseful. I'm determined to make the best choice rather than the most appealing one. As I currently conceive my situation, I have considered: a. remaining in an austere environment, striving to perfect my virtue, while not focusing on anything beyond that—bearing the solitude, hunger, and so on, or b. going home, relaxing, and focusing on committing to the precepts in an easier environment, in preparation for eventually leaving home again. I am leaning towards b. Now that I have tasted the relief of virtue, it would seem simpler to solidify it at my own pace. But I could push, and give it my all, I suppose. The only things holding me back are my own choices. Any input is appreciated. Thank you Bhantes and fellow renunciates.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-08 06:22:15

Danger frequently and personally becomes apparent to me, but my actions revert to worldliness. Are these two different things—understanding and true training in making good choices? I

They are not different. If it doesn't change one's choices, it is not understanding yet. It hasn't "sunk in."

Having tasted the pleasure of renunciation, I wanted to be a lay person for a while, living alone, working a job, and practicing aloofness in regards to worldly pleasures, before going to another, "easier" secluded environment after a while.

That's not a bad outcome if it actually turns out that way, but you want to honestly reflect on why going back is more appealing. People who return home after living in a monastery very rarely uphold the same standards afterwards, despite convincing themselves that they would.

Perhaps the solitude and hunger are in themselves so bad that the mind is perfectly happy with abandoning just that and otherwise continuing the training unchanged. But more often than not, that choice is more appealing because although one will still be committed to the precepts on paper, accountability for breaking them will be significantly lower, and

that is felt as relief. There could even be a concealed expectation of a quick “top up” of sensual indulgence before you take the precepts seriously again.

If the latter is the reason, then the mind is trying to seduce you into giving up the training and not just the austere environment—which you are of course free to do, but you’d better be honest to yourself about it.

Intrusive thoughts

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** No_Fishing_3019 2026-04-06 18:12:14

This is just a short practice question and probably doesn’t deserve its own thread, but I didn’t know where else to put it.

Say I have a desire to go on bike rides with a romantic partner, but I can’t do that because I don’t have a romantic partner, so that frustrated desire will present as aversion. At random times during the day, a thought like “I can’t go on bike rides with a romantic partner” will come up, which is then immediately followed up by a feeling of aversion, and will soon be followed up by other related thoughts that will generate more aversion or desire, if I don’t consciously intervene. My reaction may go like this:

I notice that this thought is predicated on craving and will lead to further craving, so I stop myself from engaging with it. This basically amounts to forcefully cutting it off, because the citta really wants me to think that thought right now. When the thought is gone, I notice the aversion that the thought generated and make sure not to resist it. I stay peripherally aware of that aversion until it is gone.

Is that the right way to react?

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-08 06:00:23

I notice that this thought is predicated on craving and will lead to further craving, so I stop myself from engaging with it. This basically amounts to forcefully cutting it off, because the citta really wants me to think that thought right now. When the thought is gone, I notice the aversion that the thought generated and make sure not to resist it. I stay peripherally aware of that aversion until it is gone.

Indeed. That’s how you remove the fuel for the aversion, and it eventually subsides.

What you don’t want to be “cutting off” is the underlying discomfort due to which the mind wants to think aversive thoughts (or any unwholesome thought). That’s where people often go wrong, and it’s essentially trying to stop Māra from presenting baits instead of holding the mind back from engaging with them.

The Ultimate Choice

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** LessNeighborhood1257 2026-04-06 04:21:04

Thank you in advance for your generosity in addressing this question, and forgive me for its length, but I feel it deserves special care in order to properly give you insight into the reflections of my mind. I am going to try to be as truthful as I can in my writing, so you can use your own wisdom to see any pitfalls I'm wandering into with my thinking. In this way, I hope to learn something from you and fill the glass of wisdom drop by drop.

Dear Hillside Hermitage,

You've said before that the essence of the dhamma is choice, that we have the power to shape our thoughts, speech, and actions. With this in mind, the following question naturally arises: how should we exercise the power of our autonomy for our greatest benefit? As we look into the processes of our mind, we find that we're pressured towards the sights, sounds, smells, tastes, touches, and ideas of the world. But why are we pressured towards these things, and why do we find ourselves chasing after them? We wouldn't be seeking these things if, one, they didn't provide some amount of relief and, two, we weren't experiencing a fundamental lack in our experience. But do these worldly things really provide true happiness, a happiness that doesn't age, grow sick, and die? If they did, we wouldn't have to keep chasing after them; we'd already be fulfilled on account of obtaining their pleasure. I'll call upon a simile to illustrate this further. We all start out on express trains in this life. Perhaps it's the train headed towards the ideal career that we think will make us fulfilled, whereupon its completion, we will be satisfied that we've made our mark on the world. Or perhaps it's the train headed towards the ideal partner that we think will fill the emotional lack we feel within ourselves. Then we get all excited and hop from train to train looking for the next big thing. Reflecting on the drawbacks of these behaviors, another question arises: is it worth it? And is there something more worthwhile to spend my time doing? These are the questions that you and the Buddha asked yourselves, and they're the very same questions I'm contemplating myself. As human beings with limited lifespans, it's impossible to not make choices in life. In fact, we make choices every second. And so, given the weight our choices have in shaping our lives, another question arises: what makes a good choice? As you've said before, this is the question that lies at the heart of wisdom. What, when I do it, will lead to my long-term welfare and happiness? I have seen how choices motivated by greed, hatred, worry and flurry, indolence, and anxious doubt have led to negative results. And I've seen how choices motivated by generosity, virtue, renunciation, wisdom, effort, endurance, truth, determination, goodwill, and equanimity have led to positive results. Having seen this for myself, I realize that the best way to spend my time in this life is to search for a happiness that doesn't age, doesn't grow ill, and doesn't die. However, in order to completely devote myself to this goal, the householder's life won't suffice. Using your simile, it's like a flower trying to grow through the cracks in the sidewalks of New York. With two years left of my college career, I have to make a choice. I can either wait to become a monk, finish my college education, and go forth. Or, I can drop everything like the Buddha did and start now. As the suttas remind us, for who knows? Tomorrow: death. There is no bargaining with death and his

mighty horde. In other words, it's not realistic to rely on the perception that I'll be alive in two years to go forth. The Buddha asks us to be heedful in our reflections on death. In AN 6.19, the Maranassati Sutta, we see this most clearly:

"... When this was said, the Blessed One addressed the monks. "Whoever develops mindfulness of death, thinking, 'O, that I might live for a day & night... for a day... for the interval that it takes to eat a meal... for the interval that it takes to swallow having chewed up four morsels of food, that I might attend to the Blessed One's instructions. I would have accomplished a great deal' — they are said to dwell heedlessly. They develop mindfulness of death slowly for the sake of ending the effluents.

"But whoever develops mindfulness of death, thinking, 'O, that I might live for the interval that it takes to swallow having chewed up one morsel of food... for the interval that it takes to breathe out after breathing in, or to breathe in after breathing out, that I might attend to the Blessed One's instructions. I would have accomplished a great deal' — they are said to dwell heedfully. They develop mindfulness of death acutely for the sake of ending the effluents.

If my understanding is true, from the Buddha's point of view, the best choice is renunciation. That trading a lesser happiness for a greater happiness is a noble trade. However, I feel conflicted about this choice, and after some intense probing, I realize that the difficulty in this decision lies not in giving up the pursuit of the degree, but in how my family and relatives will respond to my decision. I know I will not use this degree to get a job, for if I graduate, my job will be to seek true happiness. So, the choice here is not about renouncing the degree but about renouncing the need to be understood and renouncing the fear of disappointing others. This means that if I choose to delay my ordination, I'll have missed out on an opportunity to perfect renunciation. Am I contemplating this in the right way? That even if I do live to be ordained two years from now, I'd still have to perfect the quality of renunciation, and in making the choice to wait to be ordained, I'll have sown the seed of being liable to what others think of me. On the other hand, I am not one who abandons pursuits lightly, and I recognize the value of education and its benefits for our understanding of the world. If I wait to be ordained, I can still practice at Metta Forest Monastery on the weekends, giving me the best of both worlds while I wait to go forth. But isn't this a heedless thought? If I were to be diagnosed with a terminal illness tomorrow and told that I had a year left to live, the choice would be clear. If my relatives and family were all gone, I'd drop everything and ordain. So it seems that the root of all of this indecision is a fear of disappointing my family and relatives. Ultimately, only I can make this decision, so my purpose in writing this letter is not to ask you to make it for me, but to gain your perspective on my mind's contemplations. Thank you once again, and may you be well.

— Alex

P.S. Does samanadipa hermitage or hillside hermitage still ordain monks?

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-06 13:22:52

This means that if I choose to delay my ordination, I'll have missed out on an opportunity to perfect renunciation.

Yes, but beyond that, the idea that finishing the degree will make a meaningful difference is false. Whenever you abandon the world, the reaction of people close to you will be the same, the displeasure will be the same, and the mind's fear in regard to it will be the same—and likely greater if you wait, since you give in to that fear and thus fuel it.

So, the real question is whether you would stick to your determination to leave the world, and use that renunciation to practice rightly no matter how unpleasant that turns out to be. And it will be at least as unpleasant as the disappointment you fear. The extent of the internal problem you carry is evidently that much at least.

If you're not entirely sure that you will stick to both of those, then it's better to wait and do your best with your current circumstances. Not because of anything related to the degree, but because it can be a major setback if you end up returning home. The mind develops a “been there, done that” attitude towards going forth that makes it much harder to take it on sincerely again.

P.S. Does samanadipa hermitage or hillside hermitage still ordain monks?

Both places are operating at full capacity in terms of permanent residents for the foreseeable future.

“Or the memory that ‘feeling is there’ is established...”

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** NoArm_Boss2627 2026-04-05 23:07:47

I have a question in regards to the Sattipatthana sutta. Particularly the line:

“Or the memory that ‘feeling is there’ is established for him just to the extent necessary for knowledge and recollectedness. He abides disengaged, not taking up anything in the world.”

I can understand how contemplating ‘feelings within feelings’ and the ‘factors of origination’ relates to yoniso manisakara, but simply discerning that feelings are there seems like it can be conflated with the direct observation-(ayoniso) type meditation. I do my best just to keep a general awareness of the feeling-tone that is underlying my experience without becoming absorbed into it, and just dwell on that.

I simply note my general state of feeling, either pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. In doing so, I notice how these feelings are (A) conditioned, since I had no choice in their making, and hence (B)impermanent and not ‘for me’ . Would that constitute a correct form of yoniso manisakara, discerning that my feeling state is just there, primordial, and conditioned, and keeping that knowledge in my background awareness as I focus directly on the feelings that are there? (For example, as I’m walking, I simply discern that there is unpleasant feeling present as a context for my experience)

Can I do the same thing with moods, just note whichever mood is present, discern it as the basis or womb for experience, and dwell on that fact alone (discern that the ‘mind is just there...’)?

Or must I always be contemplating the basis for feelings/moods such as contact, perception, etc?

I understand those things to be the factors of origination.

Though I imagine there’s a good reason that final line in the sutta is included just as it is for the other three factors of mindfulness.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-08 05:51:05

but simply discerning that feelings are there seems like it can be conflated with the direct observation-(ayoniso) type meditation.

... If one has from the start misunderstood what feelings even are. Actual feelings structurally cannot be “observed” like that at all.

Would that constitute a correct form of yoniso manisakara, discerning that my feeling state is just there, primordial, and conditioned, and keeping that knowledge in my background awareness as I focus directly on the feelings that are there?

Yes, but there is no need to intentionally “focus directly” on anything. When you discern feelings where they are, that perspective naturally carries over into whatever comes up on its own.

Or must I always be contemplating the basis for feelings/moods such as contact, perception, etc?

Not always. Seeing a feeling as an arisen experience (not leaving it festering in the background unnoticed) is ideally enough for the mind to cease its engagements within it. You contemplate further only if that’s not enough for disengagement to occur.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-14 05:23:19 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

Whatever an act of observation applies to is an object in the world, not a feeling. Feeling endures *in regard to* such an act, and it has to be ignored in order to be with the content of the observation.

The same goes for all the aggregates. They cannot be observed because they are the background of observation (and of any action).

Questions on Sleep and fine Food as Obstacles in Practice

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Sa_Mahe_ri 2026-04-03 08:32:40

If I understand it correctly, it is not recommended by the Venerables to set or reduce one's sleep to a fixed amount—at least not for the initial stages of the gradual training.

But how, in that case, should AN 6.17 be understood, where the Buddha criticizes junior monks for excessive sleeping?

“But those mendicants who were junior, recently gone forth, newly come to this teaching and training slept until the sun came up, snoring. The Buddha saw them doing this, with his clairvoyance that is purified and superhuman. He went to the assembly hall, sat down on the seat spread out, and addressed the mendicants:

“Mendicants, where is Sāriputta? Where are Mahāmoggallāna, Mahākassapa, Mahākaccāna, Mahākoṭṭhita, Mahācunda, Mahākappina, Anuruddha, Revata, and Ānanda? Where have these senior disciples gone?” “Soon after the Buddha left, those venerables each went to their own dwelling.”

“So, mendicants, when the senior mendicants left, why did you sleep until the sun came up, snoring? What do you think, mendicants? Have you ever seen or heard of an anointed aristocratic king who rules his whole life, dear and beloved to the country, while indulging in the pleasures of sleeping, lying down, and drowsing as much as he likes?”

I think it has something to do with the wording of the last quoted sentence, but at the same time the criticism itself doesn't seem to directly refer to sleeping without being tired, or to waking up and then deciding out of laziness to go back to sleep. But more in line of “you are wasting your time”.

And I have another question about food and MN 7:

When a bhikkhu of such virtue, such qualities, and such understanding eats boiled fine rice with the dark grains removed and served with many soups and sauces, that is no obstacle for him. Compare this with cloth that is soiled and stained; it can be made pure and clean by pure water. Or with unrefined gold, which can be made pure and bright by a forge. In the same way, when a bhikkhu of such virtue, such qualities, and such understanding eats boiled fine rice with the dark grains removed and served with many soups and sauces, that is no obstacle for him.

I have often stumbled over this phrasing, because in my understanding it suggests that for someone who has not yet reached this level of virtue, it very well can more easily become an obstacle to consume such fine food. Would it accordingly be recommended, as a precaution to not agitate the mind, to choose—whenever possible—simpler food over more delicious options, even when the latter are not sought for their taste as such? Especially in light of the fact that the daily food served at my monastery today is probably closer to

what kings ate back then than to the food one would have received on alms round in those times.

I'd be grateful for guidance on how to understand this in practice.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-05 04:38:20

But how, in that case, should AN 6.17 be understood, where the Buddha criticizes junior monks for excessive sleeping?

Indulgence in sleep is a deliberate action that you simply abstain from, so if you feel the need to impose an external limit to prevent such indulgence, it's because you don't see what the work even is (and will most likely start indulging in however little sleep you get).

it suggests that for someone who has not yet reached this level of virtue, it very well can more easily become an obstacle to consume such fine food.

Yes, because they could be eating such food with an indulgent *intention*. Not because the food will accidentally obstruct them despite the lack of such intentions.

Would it accordingly be recommended, as a precaution to not agitate the mind, to choose—whenever possible—simpler food over more delicious options, even when the latter are not sought for their taste as such?

Definitely not. Inclining towards such a precaution implies a fundamental misunderstanding of what the mind is (namely, intention). Same as with sleep, due to tackling the problem at the wrong place, your actual mind will likely start indulging in the “simple” food you limited it to.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-05 07:23:37 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

So that they slept until the sun came up, snoring can be simply seen as an byproduct of their intention to indulge in sleep when they went to sleep

Yes. Neither of those things are themselves intentional.

So there might be some translation error as well, which I can't figure out myself.

The Pāli does contain the expression *yāvadattham*, i.e., “as much as one wants.” And *seyya-sukham passasukham middhasukham anuyutto viharanto* means “dwelling *dedicated to* the pleasure of sleeping, lying down and drowsing.”

When getting that pleasure is one's intention for sleeping, the action is indulgent no matter the duration of one's sleep. And the reverse when that is not the intention.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-14 07:19:23 (in reply to a comment not included)

But isn't the whole idea of sense-restraint that it is easier to develop the proper intention in regard to sensuality when things which make the untrained mind liable to indulge are restricted?

Not quite. It's a widespread misunderstanding that sense restraint means preventing yourself from perceiving this or that.

If you read the Suttas carefully, you see that sense restraint is always described in terms of what you don't do (on the mental level) *when* you perceive something. In this case, it's what you wouldn't do when eating even the most agreeable food so that the mind is not polluted.

Now, this obviously doesn't mean that you can eat whatever you crave for and then just practice sense restraint.

Sense restraint is preceded by establishment in virtue. Virtue in this context means that when the very act of eating something is infected with craving, you won't be eating it to begin with.

According to my (very puthujjana) understanding, sex is prohibited not because it is necessarily impossible to engage in it without grasping and delight, but because no untrained mind could accomplish this practically

Nor would a trained mind. It is necessarily impossible to engage in sexual intercourse (to initiate it or consent to it) without grasping and delight. Hence celibacy is a fixed part of virtue.

no doubt as a result of my mind's lack of conditioning, I find it impossible to eat, for instance, a grilled cheese sandwich without delighting in it and craving fatty food for days, but experience a fraction of this sensual delight in my oatmeal.

Right, so the problem is that craving, not the sandwiches. Conversely, the solution is to *abstain* from eating out of craving—which may or may not include abstaining from the sandwiches depending on the current state of the mind—rather than to perform the duty of only eating oatmeal.

Without a doubt, at any given time there will be foods apart from oatmeal that your mind does not crave for. By bundling it all into "oatmeal and the rest," you avoid the work of discerning what sensuality actually is, namely your *passionate intention* that is totally independent from the agreeability of things.

It's a less extreme form of the misguided practices of other ascetics mentioned in the Suttas, like eating only herbs and always being naked, so as to get around the need to see the current state of their mind and make choices based on that. Even if lustful states are factually avoided that way, wrong view and lack of clarity are directly fueled, and that is worse.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-15 12:31:24 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

If your mind is obsessively pulling you towards certain foods—meaning you see the threat of losing perspective and not being able to stop even before you begin—then you should definitely not go along with that pull.

Still, the particulars of a given food, be it richness or anything else, are completely irrelevant. The mind craves a certain food when it craves it, not when it's rich or light, and thus the state of the mind has to be the sole criterion.

Not seeing that is enough to set the whole effort in the wrong direction internally, despite externally abstaining from the same things as you would with the right perspective.

even nuts, an uncomfortable quality immediately taints the thought which is identical to the feeling of being pulled into a fantasy based on doubt or lust

Also, some skepticism about that reaction is warranted because indeed, it could be the result of the diet itself. I wouldn't recommend ignoring the reaction and eating the food anyway, but don't take for granted that you will always have an issue with those foods.

An attempt to clarify HH's stance on the relationship between sotapatti and celibacy

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** tejveer 2026-04-01 18:23:51

Due to some things that happened this week, I broke restraint with respect to social media, so I thought I may as well post this and then go back to restraint.

A few weeks ago, in order to substitute coarse entertainment with finer entertainment, I thought to clarify the debates around HH's position on celibacy and sotapatti. I've written and uploaded my understanding of the debate here, in case it is of use to others.

My aim in this post is to attempt to clarify HH's stance on the relationship between sotapatti and celibacy. In a previous article, HH posited that sotapatti requires celibacy, but were faced with multiple objections from others. I believe that the majority, if not all, of those objections were not well founded because they didn't understand the exact relationship that exists between sotapatti and (non-)celibacy for HH. As a result, the objections targetted positions that did not address their central claim. In writing this post, I wish to introduce exactness to that relationship.

In order to do so, I will begin by examining goals and what kinds of acts exist in the pursuit of goals. After having developed two goal-act taxonomies, I will apply them to the relationship between celibacy and the goal of sotapatti. This will allow me to express what I take to be HH's position in three claims. I will then present an analogy in an attempt to further clarify the sense of those

three claims. After doing so, I'll address common objections to HH's initial position and argue that they don't address HH's claims. Lastly, I will present a summary of the three claims by unwrapping the special terms used therein and framing them in more contemporary expressions.

As a side note, it's worth mentioning that I'm currently restraining myself from using youtube, reddit, and sutta-central as part of my larger restraint from entertainment. Because of this, I will not be able to offer sources of claims and objections and will instead have to rely on memory. This does not detract much from the overall post, however, since the central objective here is just to help me make sense of HH's position.

Would be interested to hear any critiques on this.

It's worth noting that this is currently just the first draft. A lot of the wording here is quite awkward and was fixed in the Appendix. In the second objection, I also realized that to properly present it, I would've had to introduce things that I didn't have the time to introduce, as such it remains incomplete. Do note that this post is not concerned with *justifying* their position; only *clarifying it*, and in part showing that the objections I commonly saw failed to see the central point.

I had presented this to Ven. Anigha privately on discord, and bhante stated that it was correct for the most part. There was apparently an issue that existed with a noncentral part of the post, but I no longer recall what that issue was that bhante stated - I cannot currently go on discord as I've disabled my accounts for the week.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-02 16:36:17

The point can be expressed much more concisely: if your practice does not include celibacy, then either your view of the practice is wrong (i.e., it is not geared towards purifying your mind from craving), or your commitment to practicing along the right lines is still underdeveloped (lack of a sense of urgency). Both of these are obvious obstructions to stream entry.

For a *sotāpanna* the former is not possible, but the latter will still stop them from making further progress.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-03 05:07:33 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

You're essentially saying that it's necessary to cater to people who from the start are poised to not put the teachings into practice. With that I don't mean "investigation-oriented" people as a whole—using one's reasoning is not inherently wrong—but people who refuse to try to see what we are pointing at in their individual experience afflicted by suffering (which is what gives rise to faith).

That refusal is not going to end once enough justifications are given because it's an emotionally rooted habit. They will demand more rigor in some other respect, and meeting that demand will only help them procrastinate approaching the Dhamma at the level where it is (presently evident and verifiable).

It's the same principle that is described here.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-03 05:11:12 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

the Buddha did not consider this to be the case.

What is this belief based on?

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-04 04:19:52 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

even a noble disciple may still indulge in sensuality, and the life of a householder will not lose its significance for him.

Yes, and as I wrote in the second alternative above, that would come from being uncommitted to the training.

The Buddha went on to give a long exposition to Mahānāma on the dangers of sensuality because not giving it up is precisely what was holding him back.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-04 07:09:59 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

They are constrained by this perception because don't know whether the cost of the practice (suffering from restraint), is worth the benefit (freedom from suffering). This is because they aren't able to perceive any appropriate initial grounds that may indicate to them that that benefit can indeed be received from the cost.

Yes, and my point is that they won't perceive those grounds through more rigorous argumentation, so it's a waste of time and effort for both parties.

The daunting difficulty of the practice will only be taken on if a person feels that the alternative is not only worse, but inescapable: "I am prey to suffering" is seen acutely and personally, as a necessary property of one's entire existence. Seeing that liability automatically makes theoretical justifications for the practice redundant, just as you don't need a logical proof to justify trying to remove an arrow from your chest.

If the problem does not manifest to one on that level, then one's commitment will not be sufficient to go "against the grain" of one's personal desires and obsessions. Thus, no

matter how closely one follows the Suttas on paper, one will not be committed to the actual Dhamma but to something that merely sounds like it.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-04 11:54:43 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

You are conflating “being unable to return to sensuality” with practicing in line with the Dhamma.

Being celibate and withdrawn (which is what we have stated as a requirement) doesn't mean you are beyond sensual desire. It means you don't *give into it*, which is how you go against the stream and make progress towards the cessation of craving.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-04 13:03:48 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

That doesn't contradict the point at all.

Mahānāma was lacking in diligence, which as I mentioned in the first comment above, is possible for a noble disciple. Seeing that lack of diligence, the Buddha spoke about the dangers of sensuality hoping that Mahānāma would gain enough of a sense of urgency to fully give up wrong intention.

If his enjoyment of sensuality was not the cornerstone of his lack of diligence—and was instead a dismissable symptom of not developing something else—the Buddha would've given him a discourse on that other thing instead of on the dangers of sensuality.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-04 15:11:33 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

So, you're proposing that it's not a problem for a person to engage in sensuality, maintaining their reliance on that form of happiness, when they don't know a better form of happiness. They are free to continue to do so; they just need to train in “mindfulness”—an exercise that is clearly done at the expense of acknowledging that craving is the root of suffering, and that wrong intention must be abandoned.

That exercise will somehow lead to the same result as the mindfulness that the Suttas do teach—mindfulness which *is* geared towards abandoning craving, and would thus be along the lines of remembering to not give in to sensual urges whenever they arise. This “mindfulness” also bypasses the Buddha's statement that someone who still enjoys sensuality cannot abide in internal calm.

Does that not sound like magical thinking?

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-04 19:10:47 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

The idea that celibacy is a prerequisite for entering the stream does not come from the Buddha.

The idea that it isn't a prerequisite doesn't come from the Buddha either. Both are interpretations.

In other words, what about the elimination of the ignorance?

Denying non-sensuality as a necessary part of the practice is undeniable ignorance of the four noble truths here and now: following the most blatant form of craving while trying to solve the problem means you ignore that craving is the origin of the problem.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-05 13:48:19 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

The prerequisites are explicitly listed by the Buddha in many suttas as the factors for the stream-entry, and celibacy is not listed among these factors, even once.

That's because for someone who rightly views practicing in line with the Dhamma (a factor for stream-entry) as practicing towards the cessation of craving, the need for celibacy will be obvious. Just as it was to the entire Saṅgha before any rules were laid down.

A layperson who engages in sexual activity within the framework of observing the five precepts is not breaking any rules, whereas a monk who engages in a similar act commits a grave violation of the Vinaya—he commits a parajika offence.

That's secondary; both are engaging in wrong intention. The Vinaya is an impermanent framework that will one day be forgotten, but wrong intention will always be wrong intention and lead to the maintenance of craving no matter who you are.

Plus, that a monk receives the same penalty as murderer for such an act is no accident. See how the Buddha tells Sudinna that what he did was the direct opposite of the spirit of the Dhamma.

Right mindset to benefit from the confession server?

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** spiffyhandle 2026-04-01 11:39:31

I was in the confession server for six weeks, but it didn't help me. Ironically, it made my practice worse. I wonder what I did wrong. Some people say they benefit a lot from it.

First, I found it neurotic to keep a list of every instance of breaking a precept. I'd prefer to go by memory, but the instructions say that I must report every violation. I cannot

remember every violation unless I write them down.

Second, is there a helpful mindset to approach the confession server with? I joined the server with a vague hope that it would be helpful. At first, I tried really hard to keep the precepts because I thought it was embarrassing to admit to others that I broke them. But after two weeks, I stopped being embarrassed. Then, I gradually slid into breaking precepts more and more because I started with a weak internal reference point **and** I lost my external reference point (embarrassment). Something about reading other people's confessions made me feel like my own violations were more acceptable.

Since leaving, I've found some improvement in precepts through Uposatha. I find I can keep the precepts for one day and then that has momentum into the rest of the week. And I'm starting to experience why the precepts are important and how they relate to my mind.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-01 15:13:00

I'd prefer to go by memory, but the instructions say that I must report every violation.

The rule says:

Make sure to list every transgression that you recall, and not only the ones you think are important.

The point being, *when* you recall something that is clearly a transgression, you confess it instead of giving yourself the chance to explain away the confession as not necessary in that particular instance. So the rule is "don't intentionally cover things up" and not "don't accidentally forget anything."

At first, I tried really hard to keep the precepts because I thought it was embarrassing to admit to others that I broke them. But after two weeks, I stopped being embarrassed. Then, I gradually slid into breaking precepts more and more because I started with a weak internal reference point and I lost my external reference point (embarrassment). Something about reading other people's confessions made me feel like my own violations were more acceptable.

It's a common misconception that confession helps by producing an external sense of embarrassment. But that embarrassment is indeed quite ephemeral and won't take you very far.

The right shame (*hiriottappā*) comes from failing at something that you were sincerely devoted to (hence *saddhā* comes before *hiri* and *ottappā* in the list of five powers). The external act of confessing cannot by itself ensure that you are sincerely devoted to purifying your conduct, nor that the right sense of shame and the resulting effort arise.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-04-03 06:53:23 (in reply to a comment not included)

Is this hiriottappā then? I mostly wonder about the the anxiety there if it should be felt this way.

Potentially. The shame needs to come from feeling that you failed yourself by doing what unavoidably harms you, not from having failed in the eyes of someone or something external.

Arahants laughing

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** craveminerals 2026-03-16 16:53:33

Would an Arahant laugh?

Ñāṇavīra Thera wrote about humor and laughter, suggesting that laughter is closely bound up with fear or experienced threat—such as that arising from contradiction—and may appear when that threat is seen as harmless or passes.

He writes:

“We laugh, then, when fear passes; we laugh as a charm to make fear pass; and we entertain imaginary fears to make ourselves laugh.”“Laughter, then, is not so much a reaction to fear as its counterpart ... He [the sekha] is already leaving behind him both laughter and tears.”

If an Arahant’s mind is free from sorrow, anxiety, and tension (see SN 22.43), it is unclear whether laughter could still arise. (If it did, it would presumably be of a different kind than we usually express, or only as a smile)

Could it occur purely as a bodily reaction—like from an illness— or would laughter imply that there is some tension in the mind?

Edit: reworded for more accuracy

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-03-17 15:28:57

The Buddha said that *too much* laughter is regarded as childish in the noble one’s discipline. Besides, notice that unlike dancing and singing, he does not speak of “destroying the bridge” in regard to even this childish laughter. In other words, it’s not something you would categorically fall away because it’s not intrinsically unwholesome, but you should try to avoid it because for people whose understanding of the Dhamma is still shallow and who take you as an example, it can easily be interpreted as an allowance for laxity in regard to actually unwholesome things even when it’s not unwholesome for you internally.

The Buddha himself supposedly never laughed, and that makes perfect sense given that he had refined his outward demeanor beyond the minimum threshold of an Arahant (who

is only incapable of five specific actions.

That refinement was only natural given the weight that his image had to carry as the absolute highest authority on the Dhamma.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-03-17 19:27:05 (in reply to a comment not included)

Being unable to take “a course of action influenced by desire, aversion, muddledness, or fear” wouldn’t eliminate laughter, then.

Yes, and laughter isn’t even an action many times. Action requires intention, and laughter can happen despite one’s intention being actively set on the opposite.

In reading some of Ñāṇavīra’s thoughts on this, he seems to be saying something true. But there’s also a possibility that what he describes is quite removed from “real life” and how things actually work.

Yes, he definitely had a philosophical bent, and that’s often at odds with the Dhamma. Granted, he openly admitted that he was writing all those letters to pass the time, having lost the motivation to strive further due to his sickness. He himself likely didn’t see those ideas as fundamental to the training.

If I may ask another question, what do you make of the “laughing wisdom” in SN 55.24, that spiffyhandle mentioned in their comment, what does that mean?

Hāsapaññā is used for Ven. Sāriputta in SN 2.29 and elsewhere, so it can’t be connected with Sarakāni’s drinking habit.

It could simply mean “endowed with wisdom that brings happiness.” But that would be strange according to Pāli convention, since it would be an outlier in a list of terms that all have very similar meanings.

Perhaps *hāsa* is derived from (or is a corruption of) *hamsa*, which means swan. In the Suttas, the swan is sometimes used to convey swiftness, which fits with the other qualifiers in the SN 2.29 list.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-03-18 18:01:03 (in reply to a comment not included)

I wonder if that’s the skill to bring about laughter and joy in others when giving dhamma talks.

No, it couldn’t be a “skill” in a Dhamma context. It would at best remain as a habit built up from before, and a mostly counterproductive one at that. Hence the Buddha’s own example.

Wrong meditation as an aid for establishing virtue and sense restraint?

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Financial-Wallaby316 2026-03-06 16:11:58

so a non stream enterer can't practice meditation in an actually correct way, but can one use a technically wrong practice as a tool to help establish the foundations of a right practice if they understand that that meditation technique isn't what will lead to right view? For example, if a meditation practice gives you a level of mundane mental clarity that helps you keep the 8 precepts, or it helps you stay recollected of the dhamma for the rest of the day after your practice which also aids in practicing virtue, or even just as a less destructive form of sensuality, that you can give in to before you know how to endure things at the right level, instead of giving in to things at the coarser levels of body and speech. Or if it helps you become more aware of your intentions and reasons for acting at least on the level someone without right view is capable of, and more peripherally aware of things like feelings and intentions and the body as peripherally enduring things that are the basis for anything you could ever conceive of doing, to the extent a non stream enterer can understand. Can a meditation technique be a sort of "last thing" that is abstained from, after coarser ways of acting out are abstained from?

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-03-07 04:25:33

What this common argument fails to see is that replacing lust and aversion with delusion is not progress at all. Delusion is the worst of the three defilements.

In other words, it's far better if you try and you fail to restrain your actions in the ordinary self-aware state than if you succeed in restraint thanks to a hypnotic state (which is not what **samādhi* is).

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-03-09 04:16:30 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

This makes me think that maybe if I simply stopped deluding myself about these practices and their relationship to buddhist practice, they could remain in my life the same way as any other activity, as another thing I do whose intentions I need to interrogate and reflect on and avoid doing for the wrong reasons as best I can.

Yes, that's reasonable. Even if you already don't see them as part of the training though, keep in mind that the more you succeed in the actual training, the less you will resort to *anything* for the sake of managing dukkha.

Question about virtue, entertainment, and understanding the emphasis on celibacy

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Global_Ad_7891 2026-03-04 22:55:25

Hello everyone,

I apologize in advance for the long winded post. Thank you to whoever reads the whole thing and provides feedback.

I've been reflecting recently on the precepts and my own conduct over the past several years, and I wanted to ask a question both about virtue and about the role of certain precepts.

I first came across Buddhism when I was around 19 or 20 (I am now 26). At that time I read the five precepts and essentially just agreed with them. But I didn't really understand them deeply or consciously "undertake" them in any formal sense. Looking back, I think I simply encountered them, thought they made sense, and continued living in accordance with them.

In many ways I was already following most of them before I even encountered Buddhism. I had a fairly sheltered life growing up and generally wasn't inclined toward things like stealing, lying, or harming others. I'd argue that my virtue was perfectly in line with the 5 precepts except for a 2-3 year bout of smoking a lot of weed in high school. That period ended when I was 19 years old, which was influenced by encountering Buddhist teachings. Since then — about 6–7 years — I haven't used drugs or alcohol at all despite many attempts to coerce me into taking them.

I was also already living fairly simply. I never cared much about appearance or beautification, and started becoming a loner in high school, so frivolous speech and socializing were never really a big part of my life. Also I dropped out of college at 19 years old, around the time I discovered Buddhism, and I started working in a warehouse and had no friends.

For work I mostly drive a truck and manage a few properties, which means my days are spent doing fairly simple tasks — driving, cleaning, fixing things, scheduling service calls, picking up supplies, etc. So I'm alone a large portion of the day. I also talk to myself in my head a lot.

About three years ago, I lost around 70 pounds and changed my relationship with food. I started eating once per day and have maintained that pattern since then. This is mainly due to reading about OMAD and its benefits in regards to eating a keto/carnivore diet, which is what I am currently on. The diet change also relieved a lot of my food addictions to various unhealthy foods and snacks.

In regards to celibacy, in the past I would abstain for long periods and then occasionally lapse, but over the past year I've been 100% celibate and find it extremely easy to maintain.

The one area where I clearly see weakness is **entertainment**. For many years I relied heavily on distractions like video games, movies, YouTube, and sports watching. Only in

the past few months have I started reducing those things, and just recently I've decided to seriously try abandoning entertainment altogether.

This leads to two questions.

First, I'm curious about the **strong emphasis placed on celibacy** in many teachings. I understand that sexual desire is very coarse and powerful, but in my experience once abstinence becomes established the pull weakens dramatically. Even when encountering sexual imagery online or seeing attractive people in public, there's very little reaction compared to how things used to be.

By contrast, **entertainment feels much subtler but harder to deal with**. It doesn't feel like a strong addictive pull the way sex can, but there's a persistent tendency to fill boredom or discomfort with distraction. It seems easier to overlook and justify.

So I'm curious why celibacy is often emphasized as being "more important" than entertainment, when it seems possible that things like entertainment and distraction could themselves be a major obstacle to insight into the Four Noble Truths or stream entry.

My second question concerns virtue and progress on the path. Although I didn't consciously "undertake" most of the precepts with a clear understanding of their purpose at the time, I've ended up living in accordance with many of them for years. In most cases this happened simply because the opposite behavior felt unpleasant or emotionally disturbing. For example, lying tends to feel painful and emotionally driven, even if only subtly. The same goes for things like harsh speech, stealing, or acting out of strong craving. In that sense I feel that a certain degree of restraint developed somewhat naturally even before I understood the framework of Buddhist virtue.

Because of that, I sometimes wonder whether it's reasonable to think that a **fairly stable foundation of virtue** might already be present, even if my understanding of it was initially incomplete. In my day-to-day life the only thing that still seems to exert a consistent pull is distraction through entertainment or the tendency to avoid boredom. Aside from that, the inclination to break the other precepts feels almost nonexistent. So I'm wondering whether this kind of situation would generally be considered a meaningful foundation of virtue, or whether without properly understanding the precepts from the start one would still need to essentially begin again from a more basic level.

Part of why I ask this is because it seems that in the Buddha's time many people were already living quite virtuous lives before encountering the Dhamma, and some attained stream entry upon hearing relatively brief teachings. So I'm curious whether virtue established in this kind of indirect or intuitive way could play a similar role, or whether proper understanding of why you are building virtue has to come, and THEN you start training in the 8 precepts, and THEN you can use that virtue as a basis for insight.

My other question concerns **understanding the mind more deeply**. Sometimes I find it difficult to imagine how seeing the "signs of the mind" could appear fundamentally different from how experience already presents itself now, aside from removing distractions like entertainment. At times I even feel unsure what further shift in understanding

would actually look like. I've occasionally experienced states of seclusion from sensuality when abstaining from entertainment for extended periods, accompanied by a kind of steady and collected thinking, secluded from sensuality, which sometimes seems similar to how the suttas describe jhāna. But even with experiences like that, I'm not sure how they relate to genuine progress on the path.

So I suppose my underlying question is simply whether my perspective here is missing something important about the nature of virtue or about what insight into the Four Noble Truths actually involves.

I would very much appreciate any clarification or correction if my understanding here is mistaken.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-03-05 05:58:37

So I'm curious why celibacy is often emphasized as being "more important" than entertainment, when it seems possible that things like entertainment and distraction could themselves be a major obstacle to insight into the Four Noble Truths or stream entry.

The fact that celibacy is more important than abstaining from entertainment doesn't make the latter unimportant. It just means that for the person starting with neither, celibacy should be the priority.

You can regard sexuality as the coarsest and most ensnaring form of entertainment.

So I'm wondering whether this kind of situation would generally be considered a meaningful foundation of virtue, or whether without properly understanding the precepts from the start one would still need to essentially begin again from a more basic level.

It's a meaningful foundation if the abstinence comes from recognizing the peril of misconduct for yourself, such that you wouldn't engage in it even when there is an allure in it (you are not just jaded or depressed on a bodily level) and even when given full permission by every authority you follow.

I'm curious whether virtue established in this kind of indirect or intuitive way could play a similar role, or whether proper understanding of why you are building virtue has to come, and THEN you start training in the 8 precepts, and THEN you can use that virtue as a basis for insight.

The understanding of the peril in non-virtue must become intuitive (the "charcoal pit" automatically *felt*). Otherwise it's just an idea that will not hold when it really matters.

My other question concerns understanding the mind more deeply. Sometimes I find it difficult to imagine how seeing the "signs of the mind" could appear fundamentally different from how experience already presents itself now, aside from removing distractions like entertainment.

Look for anything that can still produce a sense of “drowning.” One such thing might be not engaging with entertainment despite the pull to do so.

That sense of drowning arises because the fact that craving is the root of suffering has not been sufficiently understood, so whatever solution the mind expects is not truly a solution—it’s inadvertently pandering to one craving or the other. Either craving to indulge in something specific, or the non-specific indulgence in distraction.

Some thoughts and reflections on my difficulties with keeping the precepts

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** spiffyhandle 2026-03-04 16:24:27

I see a few ways to learn to keep them. My goal is living by seven precepts plus watching intentions to see danger in the slightest fault.

The first way is jumping straight to keeping seven precepts all the time and watching intentions. A person is expected to fail a lot but this is the most ambitious standard. This is what I started with. I broke the precepts over and over and eventually it felt like I was lying to myself when I told myself that I will keep them.

The second is taking one’s current level of precepts, which for me is the five, and adding on it incrementally. Take the smallest change one can do and let that stick. When that is solid, add the next smallest change. Then, when one is keeping all seven precepts, add in virtue (danger in the slightest fault).

That approach is what I am trying now. And I am not sure it is easier than doing it all at once. The problem with doing it all at once, is I feel like I’m lying to myself because I’m breaking the precepts all the time. But, the advantage of the all at once approach is the system is self-reinforcing. Keeping celibacy, no entertainments, no beautification, time restricted eating, and watching intentions all support each other. If you can get it going.

When a person only keeps celibacy, misconduct increases in entertainments. When a person keeps celibacy and entertainments, misconduct increases in food. IME. So there is a natural benefit to keeping all the precepts at once, from the start.

One problem with with doing precepts little by little is there are large gaps in my conduct and I rely on willpower. When I don’t practice seeing danger in the slightest fault and just work on obeying the rules, I am undermining my practice to a degree. I tried watching my intentions only in regards to the spirit of the rule I was keeping and that was not good. I was training myself to see craving but deliberately allow myself to act out if it. For example, I might gorge on ice cream because it’s not against the rules I’d taken while at the same time noticing that I was choosing to act on greed. But then in a different situation I might tell myself with *this* precept, I need to not act of of greed, but it made things confusing and ambiguous.

Overall, it’s quite discouraging by how difficult it is to take up the renunciant precepts. I’ve

added in journaling and self-reflection (<https://youtu.be/7gx5kArzdVI>..) And I'm making my environment more suitable by reducing electronics consumption. I think this second approach of just keeping one extra precept at a time, in my case, celibacy, and building gradually has potential. However, it is so slow. It's really quite surprising how difficult this is. If you had asked me, I wouldn't have thought of myself as a particularly horny person. I never did hookup apps, and was genuinely celibate for two years. But there is such a massive difference between being celibate while knowing there's an end date and doing it for life.

In the past, I was pretty successful with the no entertainment precept. I gave up video games, music, movies, TV, books, and so on. But, I did it in the wrong order as I wasn't celibate. So I am hopeful that if I can finally figure out celibacy, the rest of the precepts will be easier.

EDIT:

One thing that helped was this video by a former addict and former MMA fighter Bas Rutten - <https://youtu.be/VFyN-2MW2FI>

Any comments, observations, judgements, on my practice, or reflections on your own practice are welcome.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-03-05 06:33:19

In the past, I was pretty successful with the no entertainment precept. I gave up video games, music, movies, TV, books, and so on. But, I did it in the wrong order as I wasn't celibate. So I am hopeful that if I can finally figure out celibacy, the rest of the precepts will be easier.

An approach that might work is seeing the danger in the slightest fault, but specifically within five precepts + celibacy. So for now, you wouldn't regard it as a fault to consume entertainment as long as it doesn't arouse any sexual intentions. But you have to remain watchful of your mental state and be ready to stop despite the pressure if those intentions ever come up from the content you are consuming (or from any activity in general).

Chinese Parallel to Kālāma Sutta

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Formal_Breath_2026 2026-02-27 23:25:44

Has anyone mentioned this Chinese parallel to the Kālāma Sutta before? The first part of the sutta mentions how greed, aversion, and delusion cause one to break the 5 precepts, similar to the Pāli version. But in the section directly preceding the brahmavihāras, it mentions abandoning abrahmacariya (ἄβραμκαρία) alongside the standard grouping of killing, stealing, lying, and various other kinds of wrong speech. It also mentions purifying the mind of abrahmacariya, lust, and longing for the possessions of others. This passage is not in the Pāli, which goes straight to cultivating the brahmavihāras after greed, aversion, delusion and the 5 precepts. Perhaps an interesting basis for further research? I wonder

if there are other Chinese suttas in which the Buddha talks about celibacy to lay-people, or in which celibacy is a standard pre-requisite for brahmavihāras.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-28 05:51:42

Perhaps an interesting basis for further research? I wonder if there are other Chinese suttas in which the Buddha talks about celibacy to lay-people, or in which celibacy is a standard pre-requisite for brahmavihāras.

Yes, I've come across many similar instances. For instance the parallel of MN 97 (MĀ 27) mentions not only that brahmavihāra involves abandoning desire and sensual thoughts, but that the brahmin Dhanañjāni succeeded in it as part of a change of direction that began with renouncing his wife.

Another one is the parallel of MN 41 (SĀ 1042) which specifies “pure precepts” and “a mind free from desire” as requirements not only for all samādhi attainments but also all noble attainments.

How to clearly see the first noble truth?

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** MajesticPurpose5622 2026-02-27 19:56:37

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Hello, it has been a few months since i started my practice. It has become, by far, the most important thing in my life and stays at least in the back of my mind at all times.

Im currently stablishing myself in virtue and practicing sense restraint, using my free time to contemplate on the nature of my existence and the teachings.

However, my mind constantly harasses me with questions and doubts about why am i doing this in the first place, i feel as if i constantly have to explain to it the purpose i have found on the practice.

I have seen the video talking exactly about how to deal with a doubtful mind and im currently taking those steps, but one thing keeps me confused.

When i question myself about my intentions with this practice, i dont see “freedom from suffering” as the first reason. Instead i think that i wish to find the best possible way to live my life, and that has happened to be in the buddhist practice.

Im beggining to understand the unsatisfactory nature of sense desires, hence i do not wish to rely on them for my satisfaction/hapinnes, and this has been the primary reason why im doing what im doing.

When i think of my main goal with this, i think about findind unconditioned and true satisfaction with my life, wich cannot be obtained through craving and satisfying my craving, but i have to make an repetitive effort to think about Dukkha.

I wonder if my practice is rooted in the right reasons. If not, how can i see things more clearly?

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-28 05:19:28

Whether you focus on wanting better satisfaction or not wanting dissatisfaction doesn't really matter, since either way the need for striving is recognized.

What's more important is to remain transparent about what is taking you away from the right satisfaction and toward suffering (i.e., your own actions), so that you don't start thinking that you can get to the right satisfaction through some kind of shortcut.

How can one understand various fruitions through Ahjan's analogy?

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** account-7 2026-02-27 18:26:45

I found the video Don't open Mara's doors incredibly helpful and clarifying. Namely, the analogy of "opening the door" when there are people knocking outside in relation to acting out of pressure was incredibly useful to me.

I'm only wondering how one would define various levels of attainment relative to that image.

Would an arhat not even have the conception of a door anymore? Or is it more that the knocking on the door (avoiding or opening it) has absolutely no pull on them anymore?

Would a stream entrant never open the door and just feel intensely pressured to open it, or would they still occasionally open it if what was on the other side was particularly seductive? In the latter case, what would differentiate a stream entrant's relationship to the door from a puthujjanas?

Thank you for your time.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-28 05:37:34

Would an arhat not even have the conception of a door anymore? Or is it more that the knocking on the door (avoiding or opening it) has absolutely no pull on them anymore?

The latter. Avoidance is its own door, so you could simply say that an Arahant has no inclination to open any door that is knocked on, having fully understood that *because* there is knocking, whatever is on the other side can only be a further nuisance.

Their citta has understood that all the way, so they don't need to make any effort to remember it.

Would a stream entrant never open the door and just feel intensely pressured to open it, or would they still occasionally open it if what was on the other side was particularly seductive? In the latter case, what would differentiate a stream entrant's relationship to the door from a puthujjanas?

A sotāpanna has the same understanding, but it hasn't sunk in to the same degree. They cannot open the worst doors again, since that requires full-on delusion, but they still need to make effort to maintain what for the Arahant is effortless.

Two Questions on Paticcasamuppada

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** thereof_be_silent 2026-02-26 02:58:44

1. Does discerning the structure happen in a gradual way or in a sudden way?

It seems like it should be gradual because through the gradual training and restraint, i.e. as a basis is developed, one can see "more" of their craving, or rather see more of its scope. And thus one can see more of the dependency/simultaneity between the craving and the feeling it has as its basis.

But on the other hand, I suspect that **seeing** even a little of the dependence/simultaneity necessarily entails seeing the entire structure concretely.

Relatedly:

2. After being settled in the precepts at the bodily and verbal level, should one try to discern the simultaneity on each "instance" of craving, while also generally aiming for mental purity?

Or should one hold off until one is settled at the mental level, where the mind is dry enough that a single sentence single is sufficient?

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-28 04:38:26

1. Gradually (AN 8.19).
2. If you're keeping tabs on the mental states driving your actions (which implies not performing unwholesome ones) then you are already discerning the "structure" where it actually is.

practice question

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Formal_Breath_2026 2026-02-21 17:59:59

Sometimes recently my mind has been trying to convince me that things which I have ascertained (to the best of my ability) are not motivated by an unwholesome intention are actually unwholesome, maybe by pointing to some surface-level grey area in which they

may correspond to the boundaries set by the precepts. The problem here is not that the thought that accuses me of doing something unwholesome is unpleasant, which I know I just have to endure, but the fact that the thought appears is what makes me doubt whether I'm actually lying to myself or misjudging whether the action is unwholesome. Sort of like I feel if my actions were truly blameless, I wouldn't have these thoughts blaming me in the first place. It disturbs my clarity about my intentions, because the doubt and anxiety upsets my composure, and then I worry that that loss of composure points to the action itself actually being unwholesome. Is there any good way to know for certain that I'm not deceiving myself about whether something is unwholesome? The thing is that, when I first started practicing virtue, I feel like I actually had these doubtful thoughts less, and that they have actually ramped up since my virtue has improved and become more consistent. Like, since I have actually become less capable of lying to myself, my mind accuses me of lying to myself more, if that makes sense? I am not sure if the fact that my mind is still moved by doubt and fear about somehow 'accidentally' doing something unwholesome points to a lack of internal clarity about never breaking the precepts that still needs to be developed, or if it is just a separate stage of fear/doubt that needs to be overcome on its own. Is this over-questioning your own virtue just another way that Māra ramps up the difficulty of the practice? (only half-joking here). I hope this makes sense

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-22 11:21:20

Sort of like I feel if my actions were truly blameless, I wouldn't have these thoughts blaming me in the first place.

That's a trap. Of course, the fact that those thoughts grip you means that *something* is off, but that doesn't mean that the mistake is what the thoughts are telling you it is. Those accusations can easily be baseless and irrational.

Is there any good way to know for certain that I'm not deceiving myself about whether something is unwholesome? The thing is that, when I first started practicing virtue, I feel like I actually had these doubtful thoughts less, and that they have actually ramped up since my virtue has improved and become more consistent. Like, since I have actually become less capable of lying to myself, my mind accuses me of lying to myself more, if that makes sense?

First of all, ask yourself if you have broken a precept (i.e., did something aiming for one of those results even if it didn't actually happen). If you haven't, then the impurity there is the pressure of remorse, which blames the past to seek relief from the suffering that is there now.

If you have broken a precept, then still, you are suffering now because of craving you have now, but then you also have to recognize that you won't be able to abandon that present craving unless you abstain from such actions from now onwards.

MN 43's Parato Ghoso Usage of right view,

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** upasakatraine 2026-02-11 08:49:07

Bhante u/Bhikkhu_Anigha, may I request some clarification on MN 43's reference to two conditions for the arising of right view: parato ghoso and yoniso manasikāra.

My current understanding (which may be mistaken) is that this refers to the arising of right view as a conditionally dependent factor, not yet the irreversible Dhamma-eye associated with stream entry. My observations are as follows:

MN 43 presents parato ghoso and yoniso manasikāra as *conditions* (paccayā) for the arising (uppādāya) of right view. This suggests something dependent and contingent (arisen), rather than something already structurally irreversible — which is what the opening of the Dhamma eye (i.e. capitalized Right View is). I also noticed that in your translation you have used the un-capitalized 'right view', so perhaps this was intentional to refer to something apart from the supramundane attainment?

If these two were sufficient for the decisive and irreversible vision, then hearing correct Dhamma and attending appropriately would seem to guarantee noble entry "then and there." But the suttas elsewhere imply that right view can fail to arise even when the right Dhamma is heard AND yoniso manasikāra is present, due to resistance or remaining obstruction (e.g. The Buddha declaring that King Ajātasattu, had it not been for his patricide, would have in fact entered the stream)

Although verbs of "arising" (e.g., *cakkhum udapādi* in SN 56.11) are used for awakening itself, that alone doesn't seem to settle the issue. The decisive factor seems to be what is being described and how it functions structurally, rather than the morphology of the verb.

The suttas often speak of right view arising in a conditional sense prior to noble entry, whereas the Dhamma-eye or irreversible vision is described with additional language such as "fixed in destiny," "no longer liable," etc. MN 43 lacks that irreversible framing.

Based on these, it seems to me that MN 43 is pointing to the necessary conditions for right view to arise in a still-dependent sense, rather than directly describing the decisive and irreversible breakthrough. So in that sense, they are necessary but not sufficient conditions (sufficiency coming with the removal of what obstructs)

Is this distinction valid? Or should MN 43 instead be understood as referring directly to the irreversible establishment of Right View that marks entry into the noble individuals?

I would be grateful for correction if this framing is misguided. Thank you!

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-11 16:41:58

I also noticed that in your translation you have used the un-capitalized 'right view', so perhaps this was intentional to refer to something apart from the supramundane attainment?

No, that wasn't intentional. I wouldn't make such a distinction on my own, nor try to find a justification for it the Suttas.

I don't see why right view having conditions implies that it is reversible. Arahantship depends on plenty of conditions, yet it is irreversible.

If these two were sufficient for the decisive and irreversible vision, then hearing correct Dhamma and attending appropriately would seem to guarantee noble entry "then and there."

Yes, it would. The catch is that one has no stable internal reference point to distinguish *yoniso* from *ayoniso*, nor the accuracy of an utterance, until after right view. At the same time, what needs to be done is clear: establishing the mind in virtue and abandoning passion for sensuality is what makes one's attention *yoniso*. Hence the stock passage preceding the attainment of stream-entry.

But the suttas elsewhere imply that right view can fail to arise even when the right Dhamma is heard AND *yoniso manasikāra* is present, due to resistance or remaining obstruction (e.g. The Buddha declaring that King Ajātasattu, had it not been for his patricide, would have in fact entered the stream)

Having killed his father meant that King Ajātasattu couldn't have *yoniso manasikāra*, at least not sufficiently. Extending the right utterance of another—that all actions based on defilements are unwholesome and unjustifiable—to the right level (where nothing is excluded) will evoke in such a person a level of remorse that is impossible to bear. He had to continue regarding what he did was to some extent excusable (wrong view) in order to maintain his sanity.

It's for the same reason that the mind needs to lose its passion for sensuality for right view to arise. While still being passionate for something, let alone pursuing it, the fact that one's passion is actually the very source of one's suffering cannot sink in. The mind will reject the right view because it has something against it that it needs to protect.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-12 07:57:02 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

I can extrapolate that this applies not only to sensuality (sensual passion) but to aversion as well — insofar as both are forms of passion toward feeling.

Yes, but not as a separate aspect. If you're truly undermining all your passions, aversion has no foothold whatsoever. Hence the Buddha often using the word "passion" (or "delight") to encompass every potential defilement.

That makes *yoniso* far more existential and less technical than I had been subtly treating it.

Absolutely. *Yoniso manasikāra* is a result of the citta being tamed and pliable, not something anyone can do by following a protocol. Passion structurally carries ignorance.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-12 08:02:14 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

Since the “utterance of another”, i.e the right instructions have basically been heard countless times by this point I assume that one wouldn’t necessarily be actively “trying” to get the right view.

In the sense of reflecting on what one has heard, no, not always. But it’s also not something you can preemptively decide.

When clarity about the practice is fading, you have to revisit the right instructions (mentally at least).

Beauty, Ugliness, Danger in the Body

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Seekfinderin 2026-02-09 23:38:53

In the last weeks I was reading more and more Suttas and articles and listened to many talks and almost everything I read or listened to, and the more I did so, seemed to make sense and be very logical and convincing to me. But I have a very hard time to understand the way how you seem to look at the human body and why. I remember this Sutta, that is also quoted often in your talks, where apparently Buddha said about a princess or some girl that he would not touch her even with his feet, because, apparently that was so disgusting in his view, even though in the eyes of most others she was probably beautiful.

Then I hear you, when talking about the body, about it being that sack of flesh and blood and excrements and urine. I don’t understand that. It makes some sense to me and I am trying to reflect about it, that some things, actions, thoughts etc., that I consider desirable may not be so desirable from a more complete, neutral, clarified point of view. But in regard to this description of the body this feels to me as if you just try to look at it in this disgusted way for some reason by choice, and it seems to be very abstract to me. Because in fact and according to what I see this body is not that ugly, dirty, filthy thing. Yes, there is something like that within it, within its organs, but all that is quite in order, functions well, is surrounded by smooth skin, held together in that form, can move very elegantly and softly. When you talk about it, it sounds as if you are seeing a body when it is exploded on the floor like in a crime scene. When I reflect on this I don’t see why I should imagine something like that as it is so far away from how the body of a living human being is usually appearing?

Of course, if I would have such a negative view of the body, it would be much easier to restrain the senses and not desire to touch other bodies etc. But right now, to be honest, and please correct me, if I am wrong, it seems to me as if you just consciously cultivate such a disgust for the body in order to get rid of sensuality/sexual urges, without this having a basis in regular experience of human bodies?

To get to the point: Maybe someone can explain to me how such a disgust for the body evolves and why? And why that may be necessary or a natural occurrence on that path.

I don't get it. While so many explanations convince me and help me withdrawing more and more, this particular area is very confusing to me.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-10 05:59:28

But in regard to this description of the body this feels to me as if you just try to look at it in this disgusted way for some reason by choice, and it seems to be very abstract to me.

Emphasizing ugliness is certainly a choice, yet no less so than emphasizing beauty is. It's just because in the beginning one is so used to (and pressured towards making) the latter choice that it feels like it happens on its own.

When I reflect on this I don't see why I should imagine something like that as it is so far away from how the body of a living human being is usually appearing?

You don't need to, and that's not what the Buddha described. He said you reflect on the organs of "this very body" as you would be reviewing a sack containing different types of grains and beans. So rather than an abstract "bodies can become like that", it's "*my body already is like this.*" And that is undeniable. It may feel *unnecessary* to think about it, but that's something else (and it's the pull towards delusion).

But right now, to be honest, and please correct me, if I am wrong, it seems to me as if you just consciously cultivate such a disgust for the body in order to get rid of sensuality/sexual urges, without this having a basis in regular experience of human bodies?

If you reflect properly as above (rather than taking asubha as a mechanical "meditation object") it does have a basis in your own experience all the time. And that is why it would *uproot* sensuality, not just push it aside.

Though you may not realize it, you (*choose to*) relate to your own body as an instrument for pleasure all the time. Particular sensual desires are just the byproduct of that. Asubha is meant to change that deeper relationship with the body. Replacing sensual thoughts with shock reactions changes nothing fundamental.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-10 16:42:36 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

But all of these things are things that were in one short moment or will happen at some point in the future etc.

The point is that asubha is not about future possibilities. The body can reach such levels of "shocking" unattractiveness in the first place because of the unattractive aspects (blood, flesh, waste-producing glands) that it already has *now*, while it is factually young, healthy, good-smelling, etc.

You need to recognize the unattractiveness *within* the beauty; otherwise you'll indeed just be covering up the good parts in order to fabricate a "dispassion" that is not even genuine and will not last.

Questions on Contemplating

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** ConditionOwn3429 2026-02-08 12:04:19

Could you clarify what contemplating the danger in sensuality really means? I hear this flying around alot, but I have yet to fully grasp what it means. Does it require a prerequisite, like virtue and sense-restraint? And how do you actually, practically do it? It would be really helpful if you could also provide an example.

For context, I've been reading a section of The only way to jhana, chapter 8: The pleasure of boredom in this chapter, Ajahn says "Practically speaking, boredom is a good way to practise. People don't see boredom as an indicator, and certainly don't see delusion as an attitude that they cultivate, despite commitment to precepts, sutta study, and contemplation." (p. 88) and "For example, if you decide to allow yourself to get bored: switch off your phone, close the doors and curtains, put away your books, switch off the television, don't do your meditation technique—then, it doesn't matter whether you sit, walk, stand or lay down—just abide in that non-activity. The mind will certainly be presenting you with something to do, which is fine—you don't need to try to get rid of those thoughts, you just don't act upon them" (p. 89). This is what I'm doing, and something that I've encountered along the way was that I impulsively daydream, and I can't control it. It's not that I can't resist the desire to daydream, the daydream in it of itself just appears without my consent.

Now how is this related to what I'm talking about? I've heard from one of the Hillside Hermitage videos that one should contemplate when pressured by "unwholesome states". So how I see it is that:

- My daydreams are to entertain me when I'm bored
- Daydreaming is an unwholesome act (it contains unwholesome thoughts of desire and pleasure)
- You should contemplate when you're pressured by unwholesome states
- You should contemplate on your daydreams.

So I understand now that I should contemplate when I unwillingly daydream, but how do I do that? In the same chapter, I read "all you need to do is to not entertain it (the mind) and establish the context of the danger, if what it offers is unwholesome and sensual." (p. 87) yes, but what does that mean? I don't understand. "You can develop the perception of danger or the perception of abandoning in regard to those thoughts (of sensuality, ill-will) so that while the mind is presenting those thoughts of sensuality, you are not wanting them, and are abandoning them because they are dangerous" (p. 87) I'm not sure where to go from here.

I would appreciate it if you could clarify my question, or debunk some of my thinking. Thanks in advance.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-02-09 06:02:36

So I understand now that I should contemplate when I unwillingly daydream

If your bodily and verbal actions are contained by the precepts and not partaking in sensuality and ill-will anymore, then yes.

What you contemplate is the danger in any behaviors of sensual or hateful nature that your mind still delights in even though you have thoroughly given them up outwardly.

You don't try to deny the potential gratification of those actions; you're simply highlighting the drawbacks that the mind wants to look away from even though they are far greater in magnitude than the gratification.

The effect of that is not necessarily immediate. The momentum towards ignoring the danger (built up by careless behavior from before) has to wear away before the recognition of the danger feels palpable and the mind genuinely "accepts" it.

Questioning Hillside Hermitage based on the Suttas: "All the Defilements", Sutta MN2

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Representative-Age18 2026-01-27 19:10:50

Foreword: I felt semi convinced after watching 20+ hours of HH videos, and I think they do have a lot of good points that deserve attention. There's obviously a lot of intelligence, dedication and knowledge to be found here. Therefore I decided to take a deep dive into the Suttas to clarify my position. Here's something I'd love to hear discussed:

In MN2: *All the defilements*, the buddha says: "Some defilements should be given up by seeing, some by restraint, some by using, some by enduring, some by avoiding, some by dispelling, and some by developing."

It does not say "All defilements should be given up by restraint and endurance".

Now, here is the sentence that I would assume HH followers would really stick to:

"Mendicants, I say that the ending of defilements is for one who knows and sees, not for one who does not know or see".

HH states that this means you have to be a Sottapanna.

The Buddha always, in the rest of the suttas, describe Sottapannas with words such as: "for one who has entered the stream", "for a noble disciple", "for one with the noble right view". When clearly describing a sottapanna, he is never vague about it. There is not one example about this. The Buddha, as the AMAZING teacher he was, NEVER clearly described a sottapanna without using EXPLICIT words. I repeat, there is not ONE example

of this. He is either totally explicit, or using diagnostic criteria. The Buddha is always very clear and upright in the Suttas, so it confuses me as to why he would describe a Sottapanna with vague terms like “for one who knows and sees”, which is so much more vague than simply “for one with the noble right view” or “for one who was entered the stream”. In the video on this Sutta by HH, he justifies it using his logic, but never once questions why the Buddha in this exact sutta is using vague wording, while every other time he speaks of Sottapanna, he uses clear, exclusive wording. Nyanamoli Thero makes the exact mistake that he warns about himself: he gets into the details of the logic that pertains to what he think is mentioned, but he forgets the peripheral context: that the Buddha is always clear and straightforward in his speech, not cryptic.

Secondly, he says “Mendicants, I say that the ending of defilements is for one who knows and sees(...)”. He does not say “The continuation of the ending of defilements is for the one who knows and sees”. It is also kind of paradoxical - why would he exclude the removal of defilements to Sottapannas only. It’s a general statement. So a person who is not a Sottapanna cannot start to end their defilements? The way I would interpret it is that the startingpoint in the journey to begin ending your defilements begins with a rational mind, not swayed by emotions such as “I don’t want this to be true because of x,y,z”.

The common interpretation about “for one who knows and sees” (...) that application of irrational thoughts give rise to defilements (hope, prayer, not using logic, or just plain non-rational thinking), however, one who sees is someone who looks at reality rationally, logically and applying their mind in such a way. Ie. you are open to look at reality unbiased and logically. Not that you need to have supramundane insight into reality.

But let’s give HH the benefit of the doubt, and assume that what he really meant was that the prerequisite for removal of defilements using these 7 methods are only to be attempted by Sottapannas. Or we can give them the benefit of the doubt, however to a slightly smaller degree and say that “one who knows and sees” does mean suttapanna, without that actually making this a clear prerequisite in the sutta. It could definitely still mean “the total destruction of defilement is only attained after suttapanna”, that does not read the same as “these following methods will only work for suttapannas”.

Problem 1. Assumption by HH: “You have to be a Sottapanna to practice” some by seeing, some by restraint, some by using, some by enduring, some by avoiding, some by dispelling, and some by developing” (MN2) ” So you already have to be a Sottapanna to practice restrain and endurance, the exact methods that HH teach is the way to Sottapanna itself? How do you become a Sottapanna if you cannot apply sense restraint until after you have become a Sottapanna? HH clearly state that a prerequisite for using these 7 methods as means to lessen defilements, is already being a Sottapanna - so how do you become a Sottapanna then, without restrain, seeing, or endurance?

Problem 2. At the end of the first method proposed by the Buddha to remove defilements (Seeing) we have this statement: And as they do so, they give up three fetters: substantialist view, doubt, and misapprehension of precepts and observance of rites and rituals. These are called the defilements that should be given up by seeing.

So a sutta aimed at only Sottapannas is an instruction of how you can become a Sotta-

panna? Ehm, what?

Now, you can discuss "wise attention" and what it really means all you want, but that doesn't take away from the context that this whole sutta doesn't make sense at all if it is only aimed at Sottapannas. That's the first argument. The second one is that the Buddha was always abundantly clear when he talked about a Sottapanna, never vague.

Just to make sure; the sutta also is not a linear progression, like you should have use seeing first, then restraint, then using etc. This is obvious, as you can't do one without the other. You can't get rid of the defilements using the method of seeing very well, while not restraining yourself at least a little bit for example.

What MN 2 actually recommends (if we give the benefit of the doubt and call "knowing and seeing"=sottapanna)

MN 2 teaches:

- **All practitioners** must learn:
 - what to attend to
 - what not to attend to
 - which method fits which defilement
 - **Without right understanding**, practice is often misapplied
 - **(With supramundane right view**, practice becomes fully effective and irreversible
- So the sutta is:

—not a gated manual usable only after awakening.

Please enlighten me

Edit: you guys keep saying there's right restraint (after sottapanna) and wrong restraint (befoe). However, it doesn't change the fact that the Buddha, in this very sutta, also recommends the methods of abandoning and developing alongside restraint and endurance, not seperating them. He doesn't say: do only restraint and endurance until you become sottapanna, then do the rest of the methods. He says: you use all the 7 methods here (including restraint and endurance, and including abandoning and dev), and you try your best, but none of them will work FULLY until you have right view. He DOES NOT tell you to only use restraint and endurance and that development can only be done after sotta-panna.

Another good point:

By user: Edit: also, this part doesn't make sense to me: "And what are the influxes that should be abandoned by avoiding? Take a bhikkhu who, reflecting in light of the origin, avoids a wild elephant, a wild horse, a wild ox, a wild dog, a snake, a stump, thorny ground, a pit, a cliff, a swamp, and a sewer. Reflecting in light of the origin, he avoids sitting on inappropriate seats, walking in inappropriate neighborhoods, and mixing with bad friends—whatever wise fellow renunciates would take to be an unsuitable setting. For the influxes, trouble, and affliction that would arise in someone who abides without avoiding these things do not arise when they are avoided. These are called the influxes that should be abandoned by avoiding."

Why is either grasping of the sign of the mind or right view needed to avoid dangerous things? This seems like a part where *yoniso* as “rational” actually fits.

My view on this is that again, anything you do after *yoniso* will actually and effectively rid defilements - doesn't mean you should not practice before *yoniso*. So similar to how the buddha wants you to avoid a wild elephant, you should on the same level practice abandoning and developing. There's no prerequisite to avoid getting killed by elephant, and there's no prerequisite to practice abandonment and developing.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-28 05:09:15

The distinction is between practicing restraint and endurance, which anyone can do in theory, and successfully *abandoning defilements* by doing so. A *puthujjana* can and has to practice restraint, but that restraint will itself be tainted by defilements as long as they're a *puthujjana*, so cultivating it further will not lead to Nibbāna. Hence it's not what is being described in the Sutta.

So, rather than taking restraint as a “method” that is already correct, a *puthujjana* would keep continually questioning their ideas about what restraint is (and you can only meaningfully upgrade your understanding of something if you're also doing it). That's how they would move closer to *yoniso manasikāra*.

The same point is found in AN 2.11:

“There are, bhikkhus, these two powers. What two? The power of reflection and the power of development. And what, bhikkhus, is the power of reflection? It's when someone reflects: ‘Misconduct of body, speech, or mind has a bad, painful result in both the present and the future.’ Reflecting like this, they give up misconduct of body, speech, and mind, and develop good conduct of body, speech, and mind, keeping themselves pure. This is called the power of reflection.

And what, bhikkhus, is the power of development? In this context, the power of development is the power of the trainees. **For relying on the power of a trainee, one gives up passion, aversion, and delusion.** Having given up passion, aversion, and delusion, one doesn't do anything unwholesome, or engage in anything harmful. This is called the power of development. These are the two powers.”

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-28 06:00:23 (in reply to a comment not included)

This sutta makes it abundantly clear that abandoning and developing is also recommended for *puthujjana*'s.

It explicitly says that a *puthujjana* fails at practicing *yoniso manasikāra*.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-28 07:00:11 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

it also says you will fail at restraint and endurance, it doesn't say you don't do any of them.

We're not saying that either, as you have yourself noted.

Regardless, you don't have a strong enough position here to tell me or anyone to stop practicing meditation (partly abandoning and developing)

You're misunderstanding the point. What you're describing as "meditation" is not abandoning and developing to begin with, neither before nor after right view. It's simply distraction. So the need to give up of meditation techniques has nothing to do with enforcing right view as a prerequisite. It's to do with at least *trying* to practice abandoning and developing, which is how you could eventually attain right view.

Also, regarding avoiding: does avoiding a wild elephant to not get killed also ONLY work and is it only supposed to be applied after right view?

As a means of abandoning defilements, it does.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-28 07:33:36 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

Anyways, I've said all my points and I've said more than enough on this. It's taking too much time away from my life now, and I gotta put the computer away, so I'll leave it at this: thank you engaging in discussion with the lay community. I highly appreciate and regard the effort to actually speak to us directly. And thank you for the discussion. May you all be well, peaceful and attain true happiness, with metta - Erik

Sure, I also don't think this is going anywhere.

none of these methods will rid defilements completely unless done with *yoniso*, but that doesn't mean you shouldn't do it.

For the record, our point is that you are describing as "wholesome" *is ayoniso* in its very nature, whether one is a *puthujjana* or not. So "doing it with *yoniso*" is an inherent contradiction.

Essays in book format?

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** ghfph 2026-01-25 06:21:28

I read awhile ago that Bhikkhu Anigha's essays may be published in a paper book format.

Is there any news on this? I'm planning to rid myself of unnecessary technology (laptop and ereader), for kusala reasons, but would still like to re-read Venerable Anigha's essays.

Can I provide any help in proofreading or editing while I still have a laptop?

Thanks, ☺

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-26 05:17:13

I'm working on the book currently.

As for getting rid of technology, it's worth questioning your reasons for doing that. If it's because you can't control yourself and keep breaking the precepts when you have access to it, then it's fine to get rid of it until that's no longer the case. But if it's not that, it might be rooted in trying to avoid the practice in the name of "peace" (not having to face doubt regarding your intentions for using technology).

Question on "Definitive Guide to Seeing Your Mind" Dhamma Talk

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** CutnSkratch317 2026-01-22 21:28:22

Venerables and HH community,

Thank you for sharing this video (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Hd9WZzxqAkE>). I found it extremely informative and clarifying for my practice.

I have a question regarding Ajahn's point that one must first understand the signs of the mind by enduring, and that only once the mind is understood can "the King be fed" — otherwise, one is simply acting out of aversion or greed for a different mind state.

Here is how I currently understand this, and I would appreciate correction if I am mistaken:

Suppose an angry mind has arisen. I recognize that anger is present, and through practice I understand the dangers and consequences of an angry mind. In that case, is it appropriate to intentionally cultivate mettā (as an example) to counterbalance the anger based on that understanding - rather than out of a desire to get rid of the anger? Or would this still be considered a subtle form of aversion?

I can see how, through understanding the mind and its inclinations, abandoning it becomes easier on its own. At the same time, it seems that knowing how an angry mind operates and inclines might make it skillful to cultivate a counter-state, if such cultivation is appropriate.

Thank you very much for your time and for all that you offer to the community.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-24 09:01:03

Suppose an angry mind has arisen. I recognize that anger is present, and through practice I understand the dangers and consequences of an angry

mind. In that case, is it appropriate to intentionally cultivate mettā (for example) to counterbalance the anger on the basis of that understanding, rather than out of a desire to get rid of the anger? Or would this still amount to a subtle form of aversion?

The implication that cultivating mettā is a separate undertaking from recognizing the presence of anger, etc., suggests that it remains a form of aversion or management. Even if you do not think of it as trying to get rid of the anger, you are still just “turning the page” on it rather than addressing its causes, much like distracting yourself with a worldly unrelated activity. That does nothing to alter the underlying tendency toward aversion when attention is *not* being closely managed, which is precisely the only time that counts as a criterion for development (AN 5.200).

Mettā is the natural result of the absence of aversion. It is no more contrived than the friendliness you already experience towards people for whom you have no ill-will (which are the majority) By contrast, the common, misguided fabrication of mettā requires ignoring certain unpleasant aspects and selectively focusing on pleasant ones, and for as long as that’s at all required, you’re still just continuing to take ill-will for granted.

Hence, the ordinary friendliness of an undeveloped puthujjana toward *some* people is actually far closer to genuine *mettā* than what many Buddhists today take it to be. The difference between ordinary friendliness and the liberation of mind through *mettā* is simply that the latter is boundless/infinite. That’s the same as saying that it involves no effort or even anchor, since anything conditioned by an activity implies the possibility of its absence under certain circumstances, hence it’s not boundless. Mettā depends only on the absence of something, namely ill-will, and that absence is universal when the mind has been well cultivated.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-24 16:50:27 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

This sutta 5.200 contains the exact method that HH argues against,

Where? It talks about mettā, sure, but it doesn’t vindicate the modern interpretations of what that means, which is what we criticize.

What I intended to highlight with that Sutta is that the actual escape from ill-will is when the mind doesn’t want to go there even if you tried to send it there. Whereas the modern practices revolve around holding back the mind from what it still prefers by fabricating the opposite, without ever addressing the causes for why it in principle *could* want to go towards ill-will (or sensuality).

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-24 18:11:21 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

I agree that trying to use wholesome as a means of controlling the unwholesome, is just clinging.

That's not quite the point. The modern interpretation of mettā is just a cover-up, and cover-ups are themselves unwholesome. It's replacing ill-will with delusion, which is like switching the side of a cube you're facing while the cube remains equally close to your face.

This is what I believe can quickly happen with non-resistance, non-doing, endurance methods: We understand that aversion to discomfort is the problem, but that we are supposed to not resist it. We end up mindlessly "thinking" and never really get objective perspective, it's just a perpetual thinking "Aversion", "I'm supposed to not let this aversion take over" "Now I'm controlling" "oh no I shouldn't control" "ok stop controlling" "ok allow even that to be", and maybe it stops. Also aversion becomes the center of gravity, like we know aversion is the problem, so we automatically start 1. subconsciously looking for aversion 2. We start identifying (clinging) to aversion. We end up kinda chasing displeasure to solve our aversion, but we are now identified to some extent to aversion.

That's what happens when even what we're describing is still being implemented as a mechanical technique. That tendency might take time to calm down, and those considerations aren't of much value anyway unless you're already fully steadied in the eight precepts. If you're not, you're not going to clearly see what any defilement is no matter how hard you try.

For example: I can feel peaceful while feeling quite a lot of pain IF I stay mindful, ardent and fully aware, fully comprehending what is going on. However, if I just drift into the pain/aversion, I feel like I quickly identify with it and sink into more aversion.

Right, and the fact that the latter can still happen means that the mind is not being developed. No amount of time of cultivating such "mindfulness" will remove the need for itself. It's just learning how to cope, however successfully and skillfully, and never removing the causes for disturbance. In fact it makes the problem worse; if after getting used to that you have to face discomfort without crutches, you will be even less able to do so than before. Hence the Buddha said that a person who attains wrong liberation through wrong view ... wrong samādhi is *worse* off on that account. It's not a "transitional stage" or a "skillful means." It's a complete deviation that requires you to unlearn everything you learned.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-24 18:56:23 (in reply to a comment not included)

You're essentially telling me that on account of that, I cannot even attain Sotthapanna, and even that is contradicting the Buddha, as thousands of laypeople who indulged in sex, entertainment etc etc, did attain stream entry.

The Buddha did say that such activities are an obstruction to both right view and right *samādhī*. He also listed things that need to be given up in order to practice *satipatthāna*, and the things you mention are covered by the items in that list (AN 6.118). Elsewhere he said one can't progress in the Dhamma while maintaining delight in sensuality.

In your view, from what I interpret, I'm better off just giving up meditation practice, unless I can follow all 8 precepts and probably also live in calm environment.

Yes, you should give up the meditation you've been doing so far and anything that resembles it because it's actively taking you even further away from the right *samādhī* and peace. Giving it up will show you how your mind actually isn't tamed; how it still resists and craves for things just as strongly, if not worse, when you stop managing the scenery internally.

As for the eight precepts, it's not all or nothing.

First of all it's about being honest to yourself regarding what the goal is, i.e., freedom from craving, and the fact that you can't claim to be practicing towards that goal while you still engage in obvious acts of craving. That's probably not going to be all that obvious if you've been following contemporary teachings, and the precepts need to be supported by that simple but important recognition to be effective.

With that perspective, even though you might not be formally committed to the eight precepts all the time, there will be a lingering sense of shame each time you intentionally break them and remember your desire to train your mind, and that will allow you to grow in the precepts as quickly as you can handle. For some people that's overnight, for others it takes longer.

If you're not choosing entertainment yourself then that's not really a concern.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-26 05:32:46 (in reply to a comment not included)

That's a widespread misunderstanding.

If you have to shield and control your mind to prevent unwholesome reactions, it is not even temporarily liberated or composed. The need for suppression or redirection is itself a product of the hindrances. If that feels calming, it will be the same kind of “calm” produced by sensuality, which also depends on averting attention from what is unpleasant. Thus, it's wrong calm.

The notion that *samatha* can be developed independently of understanding is refuted by Suttas like AN 6.73 and AN 9.41.

in order to come to the experiential understanding that clinging to ill-will is unproductive?

This supposed “experiential understanding” never actually comes. Anyone who relies on these practices neither has nor will reach a point where defilements cannot arise without them. That’s because they are not just tangential; they actively manifest the same problem.

Why is business/trading in meat & living beings Wrong Livelihood?

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** ToLazyToPickName 2026-01-22 17:33:18

If buying & eating meat is not wrong action, why is trading in meat & living beings wrong livelihood?

A cook who make a living off of cooking meat, a grocery store cashier, or a pet store owner who makes a living off of selling pets, why is that wrong livelihood but consuming the cooked meat or buying/having the pet is not wrong action?

I don’t see how there is wrong intention in the livelihood of being a meat cooker or pet supplier. Maybe the meat cooker is encouraging more people to kill animals and the pet supplier is encouraging cruelty towards animals? But then why isn’t the end consumer also doing that?

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-24 04:49:33

A cook who make a living off of cooking meat, a grocery store cashier, or a pet store owner who makes a living off of selling pets

Only the last one is wrong livelihood. Cooking meat and being a cashier at a general grocery store are too far removed from the act of killing to matter.

The issue is how gaining a living from these things carries a welcoming attitude towards the acts of killing and, with pets, undesired imprisonment. Even when you’re not the one physically perpetrating either, internally your intentions are pointing in that direction to a degree simply by working in those industries.

With weapons and intoxicants, you’d be condoning the intended usage of those things by selling them (though not if you’re a cashier where those are among many of the items sold and customers take them without your involvement).

Some people think that in buying meat you are also condoning killing, but that’s a fabricated connection and not true in any sense that’s relevant for the training of the mind. You can totally maintain the attitude that you would never intentionally kill a living being

or encourage another to do so, even to save your own life, despite buying and consuming meat. That attitude is what you have to cultivate, and abstaining from meat as a rule contributes nothing to that per se. It usually takes away from it by distracting you.

The Buddha could've easily made at least monks vegetarian and thereby prevented a lot of meat purchasing. But not only did he not have that initiative; he explicitly refused when asked by Devadatta. It would've cemented a wrong view about what virtue is.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-26 04:34:51 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

To me, it seems like by relying on the death of animals to continue for their livelihood of selling or helping to sell meat

Because unless they're working directly with a butcher, the connection is abstract. They wouldn't have to be open to killing or encouraging another to kill in order to do it.

Which jobs in the meat industry would be included in wrong livelihood besides the job of doing/commanding the killing?

It depends on the closeness of the association. If the job involves any dealings with the people who do the killing, it would be wrong livelihood. Not because you're explicitly telling them to kill, but because there is automatically going to be a sense of cooperation.

Beautiful and Ugly

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Formal_Breath_2026 2026-01-16 18:22:33

I have heard Ajahn Ñānamoli say several times about how the ugly is a more fundamental context than the beautiful, and I was thinking about how to understand this concretely. What I have arrived at is that the ugly is more fundamental because that is exactly how sensuality is there at all — if things were more beautiful than ugly, it would just be a matter of avoiding the ugly; there would be no drive to go towards the beautiful. But it is the interplay between the signs/features of the beautiful and the broader context of the ugly — and the resulting *pressure* to engage with the beautiful — that makes sensual being (kāmaabhava) what it is as opposed to a mere pleasant abiding (rūpaabhava). This is why sensuality, being driven by that pressure to get away from the ugly, is always unwholesome, whereas material states (Jhānas) can be experienced wholesomely. This is also why sensuality is insatiable and unsatisfactory, as the ugly is always there 'waiting' as the broader context whenever the less fundamental beauty runs out. Similarly, if you were put in harsh enough conditions, you would start finding sensual appeal in less and less pleasant things, like an animal that enjoys eating filth. But when you develop the theme that whatever beauty in sensuality there is is only there because the broader context of the ugly gives it its appeal, it all becomes ugly and loses its pressure, and ironically that is what ultimately brings peace. The ugly is only a problem relative to the value you place in beauty, but when it's all ugly, it becomes basically neutral. The more I think about it, the

more it seems to me that this interplay between the signs of the beautiful, and the broader context of the ugly, are what make up the entirety of human existence, and developing that context is also how one can surmount it.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-17 17:15:00

The more I think about it, the more it seems to me that this interplay between the signs of the beautiful, and the broader context of the ugly, are what make up the entirety of human existence, and developing that context is also how one can surmount it.

Yes, exactly—granted one has stopped acting on desire for the beautiful no matter how invisible its more fundamental ugliness is.

The disgusting nature of your own body (the contemplation of organs often given in the Suttas) is the most acute and inescapable type of ugliness, but the principle extends to everything that you wouldn't want to look at because it would ruin your enjoyment/anticipation of something pleasant. Anything of that nature is by default more fundamental, since it's what stands out when desire isn't there to obscure it.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-17 16:59:29 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

The implication here that “jhāna is a subtler form of sensuality” is wrong. Jhāna definitionally is the complete cessation of sensuality (through dispassion, not replacement of objects).

There's no good reason to extend the word “sensuality” to everything.

Practice advice

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Embarrassed-Box6857 2026-01-15 11:04:55

Hi everyone,

Looking for some guidance and correction regarding my practice. I have been living a semi-monastic life for the past year (seclusion, simplicity, minimal stimulation) and on the 8 precepts.

I've been practicing seriously for about a year overall(used to meditate earlier from mantra to open awareness or “do nothing” meditation), but the last 1-2 months have been much more endurance based, basically dropping my meditation completely .

Current practice:

I have been at a monastery for about 50 days now and my main practice is avoiding acting out of cravings, aversion etc as much as possible. The days are often neutral/flat, I am fairly calm and used to living a restrained life without seeking much relief or stimulation.

What I notice changing after endurance :

- Cravings are weaker and less convincing
- Much greater tolerance of boredom, neutrality and less emotional reactivity overall
- Less interest in pleasure, anticipation, or planning
- Can be awake and inactive for long periods without panic

At the same time, there's dryness, grief for the past, and uncertainty. Relief feels largely unavailable, because i am not seeking it(yet at some level i still want it)but not in an urgent way, just a constant "ahh that would be nice". You could say a continuous dissatisfaction throughout.

I know endurance is not sufficient for right view/stream entry, and I'm unsure how to integrate contemplation correctly. So here are some questions to things I am trying to discern.

- How do I know whether I'm truly "letting things endure" versus just spacing out or passively waiting?

Im currently "aware" of my experience in a general sense without getting too absorbed in things. Its hard to discern whether I intentionally feed thoughts or fantasise(though my fantasies and interest in them has greatly reduced)its more like I let them do thier thing while I just "watch them". I still get fooled with the content from time to time and I can feel the confinement Ajahn talks about- everywhere my attention goes the thoughts etc follow and there is no "escape". I am not trying to move my attention to avoid them or anything. This would be enduring on the right level?

- Ajahn often emphasizes understanding the context (body sitting, feelings enduring) rather than content.

When I set the context to be mindful of my posture for example, i am supposed to bring up the knowledge that " I am sitting"- which i am aware of in the moment- however this knowledge is just a thought which im attending to, which wouldn't be the actual "body". And same with when i "recognise" i lost the context of the body, i will automatically think "oh i forgot about sitting". But thats also just a thought. As I understand this way I fail to even set the context in the first place and am just playing around with sense objects. How do i work with this?

- Should I reflect on danger/drawbacks, impermanence, etc? At times mind does takes on these topics(not to avoid anything specifically) and it's not just on an intellectual level, I am definitely able to feel the implications of my contemplation. But im still trying to discern when its appropriate, how often to do so etc.

For sense pleasures , ex- longing for something, how do i reflect on the danger in that? The danger must be independent of the content and of sense pleasures as a whole, or specifically relating to the thought? I am still at the stage where I am just enduring and not steering the mind in the right direction towards dispassion with sense pleasures and making it learn for itself. Sometimes thoughts like "this is impermanent" or other stock

phrases will arise, not to push the longing away(or it could be and im mistaken) but as I understand these are still surface level and aren't actually talking directly to the citta. Any advice for this?

Thank you for any guidance you're willing to offer.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-16 05:11:52

Should I reflect on danger/drawbacks, impermanence, etc?

Yes, that should be the main effort. It sounds like you've become habituated to the precepts and restraint externally, but without the certainty that your mind wouldn't return to those things even if you wanted it to. The only relief that's not unwholesome comes from that certainty, and it's cultivated by clarifying the danger of what you're already disengaged from.

Don't try to contemplate the danger in sensuality in some abstract sense; just clarify the danger in returning specifically to breaking the precepts. By not doing so the mind still remains open to that possibility even if it never comes up, and that's why it wouldn't be at ease. Unease doesn't require explicit confirmation that enemies are coming; it's enough not to know with full certainty that they're *not* coming. Factually, they might all be defeated, but unless you *know* that, you will still be subtly anxious.

To be clear, you're not looking for some positive announcement from your mind that the precepts will never be broken. You simply see that when you bring up the intention never to engage in misconduct again, resistance and reservations no longer arise. That means the citta is obedient to that extent (the internal enemies are defeated).

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-16 11:11:10 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

The only things I still occasionally give in to or have not 100% said no to in terms of never giving in for the rest of my life are using Dhamma as a soothing tool(especially for doubt) and to relax/enjoy, likewise with food.

Sure, but what I'm saying is beyond merely not breaking them. A lot of people haven't broken any precepts for decades and they're nowhere near the right practice. What I'm describing is the factual joy that will be felt when having not broken the precepts and become accustomed to them, you mentally establish them as an immovable context that permeates everything you do, say, or think. You actively highlight to yourself the benefit of staying within those boundaries, and the unassailable freedom from danger that it entails. "Unassailable" because nothing and no one could force you to break the precepts. It's always been your decision, and that decision has become unthinkable because the danger in it is clear.

About my other questions, about endurance on the "right level" and the body posture context, am I on the right track? And likewise for finding the line with

proliferation of thoughts and mere observation.

You can forget about that for now.

The right level is not something you do or create; it's when what you will *not* do (because it's unwholesome) is crystal clear, and abstaining from it is effortless because the mind has been trained to that degree.

Possibility and eventuality

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Puthujjana381 2026-01-13 10:51:20

Dhamma eye

The insight of the dhamma eye is usually phrased as “whatever has the nature to manifest also has the nature to cease” [yaṃ kiñci samudayadhammaṃ sabbam taṃ nirodhadhammaṃ].

Stronger statement

However, I think a few times now I've encountered (for example in Right Way of Striving) the seemingly stronger statement that “whatever has the nature of arising, because of that it *will* have to cease”.

I don't think the stronger statement that something *will* cease follows from the fact that it *might*. It's possible for something to be perpetually liable to cessation, yet for it never to actually cease.

So I'm trying to understand in what sense the stronger statement is true and how to see it. I'll write down my current thoughts on it, and would like to invite anyone with better clarity to respond and help me understand.

- First of all, I'm not sure if the stronger statement in such a form appears in the suttas, the closest things I can think of are:
 - It could have not been, and it wouldn't be for me, it won't be, it won't be for me [no cassa no ca me siyā, na bhavissati na me bhavissati] (little hard to translate to English I think, since English mixes up tenses with optative)
 - Impermanent indeed are constituents, of a nature to appear and vanish; having appeared they cease, their settling is happiness [Aniccā vata saṅkhārā, uppādayadhammino; Uppajjitvā nirujjhanti, tesaṃ vūpasamo sukho]
- I believe Ñāṇavīra Thero addresses this question to some extent in Fundamental Structure II.5. My current takeaway would be that something arisen can endure for only so many eternities (of eternities of eternities...) before it will finally have to cease. This seems feasible, but I only see it to some extent and quite abstractly, and not sure how to make it more directly felt and concrete.
- In fact, in some Dhamma talks, in order to counter the common aversive thought of “oh, this is impermanent, it will cease” to try to soothe one's discomfort, it's recommended to think “no, this is permanent, it will last forever”. I see how both of these

are aimed at dispassion: seeing the impermanence undermines attachment to the dear, while seeing that something might endure forever undermines the aversion to the disliked. Yet the truth should somehow reconcile the two without contradiction.

- I wonder if the stronger statement is actually only true *for a sotāpanna*? Since they are said to know a phenomenon (e.g. feeling), its condition, its cessation and the path leading to its cessation. The puthujjana, not knowing the way leading to its cessation, is subject to the possibility of feeling for eternity. Until that eternity ceases?

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-16 04:55:34

I believe Nāṇavīra Thero addresses this question to some extent in Fundamental Structure II.5. My current takeaway would be that something arisen can endure for only so many eternities (of eternities of eternities...) before it will finally have to cease. This seems feasible, but I only see it to some extent and quite abstractly, and not sure how to make it more directly felt and concrete.

Yes, I wouldn't recommend going that route.

I see how both of these are aimed at dispassion: seeing the impermanence undermines attachment to the dear, while seeing that something might endure forever undermines the aversion to the disliked. Yet the truth should somehow reconcile the two without contradiction.

And it does. Impermanence means that things both could end next moment or last "forever," as in far longer than however long you expect them to last. So whether you hope for novelty or permanence, your hopes are undercut by *anicca*.

I wonder if the stronger statement is actually only true for a sotāpanna? Since they are said to know a phenomenon (e.g. feeling), its condition, its cessation and the path leading to its cessation. The puthujjana, not knowing the way leading to its cessation, is subject to the possibility of feeling for eternity.

No, no quite. That would assume that there is some overall situation of being subject to feeling independent of what is currently being felt, and that's not how it works. A puthujjana remains subject to one of the three specific feelings (MN 74), and there is no stability to be found there. Even if they wanted to experience nothing but displeasure and dismay (e.g. at being puthujjana), pleasure or neutrality would take over sooner or later.

Mittasutta: satipaṭṭhāna practice for puthujjanas?

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Solip123 2026-01-12 21:27:36

In the Mittasutta (SN 47.48) the Buddha tells the monks to teach "friends and colleagues, relatives and family" the four satipaṭṭhānas.

What do you make of this?

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-13 05:08:41

It doesn't negate the prerequisites for *satipatthāna* established by a multitude of other Suttas, such as the one right before.

Try as you may, you will not be able to get someone who still looks for pleasure in the world to subdue longing and aversion in regard to the world. It's like asking them to jump off a cliff.

At best, they will be able to shift their longing to a new thing in the world, and that, though very common today, is not *satipatthāna*.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-13 08:09:15 (in reply to a comment not included)

That would only be possible if *yoniso manasikāra* was a quality independent of one's choices, but it isn't. Engaging and intending to engage in sensuality *is* *ayoniso manasikāra*.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-13 08:17:59 (in reply to a comment not included)

Neither. They're identical.

Yoniso Manasikara in practice

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Silatigi1 2026-01-12 00:41:45

Dear @Bhante Anigha

I have a very practical question about *yoniso manasikara*.

Let's say a pressure comes and I have trained to let it be, to let it exist, aka not acting out of body (grab food, look at things to buy) and speech (swearing at the pain of sustaining the unpleasant pressure, crying at the difficulty of sustaining it), but not yet by mind (not sure yet about the signs and features, at the moment more trying to survive the wave of the screaming pressure, but with the cigarette that I stop smoking many many years ago I kind of get an inkling of what this could feel like).

Now the question is how do you practically apply *yoniso manasikara*, what is it that you discern from a first person perspective?

So the pressure is there, say a restlessness, and you let it be without acting, then thanks to that pressure being here and remaining here there is something that I can discern that I could not discern if it was not there, if I (seemingly) got rid of it by acting.

So in the metaphor it would be suddenly I feel the lead of the dog pulling me when I stand my ground. I can also relate to the dog differently for the first time, I experience the dog and the lead whereas before both were invisible together to me as a pair.

Or the current of the river, and the pole I hold on to. Without the pole, no current is felt. Or the spoiled child putting on a tantrum and my resolution not to give in.

So my question is what is it that you discern from a first person perspective when the pressure is present? What is that thing that could not be seen without that pressure?

Anything concrete you could point to would be very helpful e.g ideally several different practical examples of pressure and what one could discern while enduring patiently the pressure.

Because unfortunately when I hear “with this, this” I don’t need necessarily concretely understand what the second “this” is when the first “this” is the pressure...

Thanks in advance for your help

Sil

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-13 04:56:19

So my question is what is it that you discern from a first person perspective when the pressure is present? What is that thing that could not be seen without that pressure?

The fact that all satisfaction of the pressure is actually still within suffering. You get to see first-hand that the presence of craving, not the lack of its fulfillment, is what suffering is.

How Should Buddhist Cosmology be Interpreted?

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Additional_Fix8417 2026-01-09 15:24:05

Currently reading AN and noticed how characters such as “King Yama” and “wardens of hell” inflict pain on the man who in the past performed “bad kamma”.

Assuming the former two characters were true, would they have the choice (of action; kamma) to punish or not to punish the “evil doer,” thereby abandoning kamma for themselves? As such stories if taken literally may just undermine the legitimacy of the law of kamma in relation to re-becoming, since characters such as “King Yama” and “wardens of hell” may not have the choice not to act in a way that inflicts pain on another, whether or not that other individual “deserves” it).

Should these stories be regarded metaphorically and that these characters are in a way manifestations of one’s own kamma? Mere lores largely inherited by preceding cultures and traditions?

Sutta reference: AN 3:36

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-11 10:29:29

Assuming the former two characters were true, would they have the choice (of action; kamma) to punish or not to punish the “evil doer,” thereby abandoning kamma for themselves? As such stories if taken literally may just undermine the legitimacy of the law of kamma in relation to re-becoming, since characters such as “King Yama” and “wardens of hell” may not have the choice not to act in a way that inflicts pain on another, whether or not that other individual “deserves” it).

No, that doesn’t follow at all. A soldier may have an extreme pressure on him to kill for his country, potentially facing severe consequences for refusing to do so. That doesn’t in any way diminish his accountability for killing.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-11 11:56:23 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

Yes, that’s what I’m referring to as well. Them being born to perform those roles doesn’t mean they’re not responsible for actually performing them. So the principle of kamma still applies.

It’s no different than how human existence is made for sensuality and reproduction. If you want liberation, you don’t do what your birth is meant for.

What should I do if I struggle to discern intentions of greed, aversion, or delusion?

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** Solip123 2026-01-07 06:06:35

Will this become easier to do as I become established in the precepts?

I’ve been trying to keep the precepts and gradually add more of them, but I find myself largely unable to tell when my intentions are rooted in craving. I can sort of look at the amount of pressure, the overall hedonic tone, and question the content of the intentions in an attempt to ‘triangulate’ it, but I sense that this is not the right way of going about it. This is also often doesn’t work. I will often ask myself “why do I want to do this?” or “why am I doing this / why did I do that?” and in response there will be nothing, just a blank mind.

Also, I have an additional (and somewhat related) question: what am I supposed to do when I am trying to keep the eight precepts (or something near that)? The boredom kicks in very quickly.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-10 20:17:07

I can sort of look at the amount of pressure, the overall hedonic tone, and question the content of the intentions in an attempt to 'triangulate' it, but I sense that this is not the right way of going about it.

Yes, that's going to be abstract.

What you have to do is (1) not be breaking the eight precepts currently, (2) not forget that you will not do so no matter what happens (this means avoiding anything that obfuscates that conscious commitment even when it aids external restraint, chiefly meditation techniques). That's it. The mind will certainly try to sneak out of that confinement in the beginning, but there will be no opening if those two things are maintained. Eventually it will calm down and start to genuinely prefer staying within the boundaries.

Also, I have an additional (and somewhat related) question: what am I supposed to do when I am trying to keep the eight precepts (or something near that)? The boredom kicks in very quickly.

As part of the effort to keep the precepts, you *can't* do anything besides not forgetting that you won't intentionally break them under any circumstances. Finding something additional to do in the name of practice would compromise point #2 above. As for things unrelated to the practice that you might do, you can't decide that in advance. It's whatever comes up despite the deliberate commitment to the precepts remaining ironclad.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-12 05:49:15 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

The problem is that you're still thinking in terms of what to do. That's inevitably going to leave you susceptible to doubt. If you know what you're not going to do, you will completely stop caring about what you will do. And what you're not going to do is break any of the precepts.

If the intention never to pursue unwholesome content like TV, movies, etc. is crystal clear, then whatever intention there is to consume Dhamma content will not be problematic because it won't be leaning towards entertainment. It's because the boundary is unclear, not because of any neutral actions, that there is still pressure towards the full breach (if you were to abstain from consuming Dhamma content and just stare at the wall, the same pressure towards entertainment would be felt because you're still not clear about what you won't do).

As for the peril of sensuality, breaking the precepts is what sensuality is, so the peril is discerned in regard to those specific actions. When their danger is evident, there is no way to maintain even the most fleeting intentions towards them. Instead of hunting for those fleeting intentions, which will be an endless and ultimately unsuccessful task, you ruin the appeal of what all of them point towards, so they all wither away.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-13 08:15:39 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

There's no word missing. I meant that keeping the precepts is done by choosing to keep the precepts. Any other choice has to be done with that primary choice enduring as background, not in place of it.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-14 05:16:00 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

So, I should stop indulging in less coarse forms of entertainment/distraction first and then consuming the Dhamma content shouldn't be an issue anymore?

No, you don't take for granted that you will consume Dhamma content. You maintain the context that you won't be pursuing the obvious forms of entertainment, and if the pursuit of Dhamma content had an intention leaning in the direction of those coarser things then it will be clear and you won't be engaging with Dhamma at that time. Intention is the leaning towards the obvious action even if it never ends up being done.

So, if I understand correctly, the mental withdrawal from (read: devaluing of) sensuality will occur naturally as a result of abstaining from sensuality for a long enough period of time?

No, physically abstaining from it won't do much by itself. Within the physical withdrawal, you have to contemplate the peril and communicate to your mind that it should under no circumstances go there. The point is that that contemplation is in relation to the specific actions and situations outlined by the precepts, not in regard to some abstract idea of sensuality that extends to everything and nothing.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-16 05:29:49 (*in reply to a comment not included*)

There is still, though, a certain sense that sensuality has to be something more than merely the leaning towards breaking the precepts.

It is. The root of sensuality is the lack of internal clarity that sensuality will not be returned to. If there's unclarity (muddledness/delusion), then sensuality still looms even if no explicit intentions towards it are present now. By itself, the latter is just the state of an infant (MN 78).

See also this comment.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-16 05:39:29 (in reply to a comment not included)

Is this a reasonable way of going about it, or is this style of contemplation faulty?

Yes, because it's edging towards an undefined result. What you have to do is simply reflect on your intention to keep the precepts unconditionally, and if the mind's reaction to that is at least neutral, your work is done for now, and you just have to make sure that you don't obfuscate that intention (which is how the opposite intentions begin to take root). If there is internal push-back against that intention of restraint (including in the form of doubt, not just coarse desire), *then* you make the effort to clarify the danger in breaking the precepts.

After Recognizing Sensuality as Bait for Hindrances : Right Effort to protect one from that sinking feeling.

Subreddit: r/HillsideHermitage | **Posted by:** rs_87_78 2026-01-06 07:27:37

Hello fellow practitioners,

Through first hand experience, I understand that Gross Sensuality is a trap. It is the gateway to craving which leaves one vulnerable to the other 4 hindrances.

However, I now find myself overly vigilant, guilty and a little helpless and restless. If conditional experiences are unsatisfactory and impermanent, what am I to extract a subtler more refined form of peace (Joy) from ?

Are there any interesting hobbies you guys have inculcated that reinforce wholesome states of mind ? Something that mitigates dependent behavior tendencies while also reinforcing a sense of meaning.

Which brings me to another query : If one is through conduct, abandon the aggregates, with the intention of abandoning ownership of a self, is there no room for Self-Worth ? Wouldn't this line of thinking create a void that exacerbates vulnerability to the hindrances ?

Warm regards.

Comment by Bhikkhu_Anigha on 2026-01-06 17:04:29

However, I now find myself overly vigilant, guilty and a little helpless and restless. If conditional experiences are unsatisfactory and impermanent, what am I to extract a subtler more refined form of peace (Joy) from ?

That's normal, and the solution is not to find something to relieve that confinement; it's to get used to it, which requires not going outside of it, i.e., breaking the precepts. When

AFTER RECOGNIZING SENSUALITY AS BAIT FOR HINDRANCES : RIGHT EFFORT TO PROTECT ONE FROM

it gets used to it the mind will stop resisting it, and it will cease to be unpleasant. That cessation of resistance to restraint, without anything added on top, is the only type of joy that is in line with the Dhamma, since it comes craving falling away, not from fulfilling the same need in a more refined way.

The latter keeps the mind from protesting in the immediate present, but it also means no internal training will occur even if the precepts are kept externally.

